

Mindfulness Activities for K-8 Students

A Comprehensive Reference Guide for Behavioral Health Educators and Technicians

108 evidence-informed activities across 11 categories — mapped to DBT's Wise Mind framework

Category	Count
Breathing	17
Sensory grounding	13
Movement/yoga	12
Sound/listening	9
Visualization/imagery	8
Emotion awareness	10
Body awareness	8
Compassion/kindness	9
Attention/focus	9
Social/group mindfulness	7
Transition/reset	6

This guide is for educational use by behavioral health educators and technicians. It is not a substitute for clinical supervision or professional mental-health care. Always follow your organization's policies and supervise appropriately.

How to Use This Guide

This reference guide compiles 108 evidence-informed mindfulness activities designed for use by behavioral health educators and technicians working with elementary and middle school students (Kindergarten through 8th grade). Activities are organized by category and include detailed instructions, age adaptations, trauma-sensitive considerations, and the psychological mechanisms behind each practice. Each activity is also tagged with the DBT states of mind it engages — Emotion Mind, Robot Mind, and Wise Mind — so educators can connect mindfulness practice directly to DBT skills training.

Activity Categories

Breathing (17 activities)

Pinwheel Breathing, Teddy Bear Belly Breathing, Four-Square (Box) Breathing, Breath Ball (Hoberman Sphere), Balloon Breathing, Flower & Candle Breathing, Bee Breath (Humming Exhale), Count Your Breaths, Shape Breathing, Ocean Breath (Whisper Breath), Rainbow Breathing, Feather Breathing, 5-Finger Breathing (Star Fingers), Snake Breath (Long Slow Exhale), Belly Breathing with Hand on Heart, Breathing Buddy (Object on Belly), Noticing the Pause (Between Breath)

Sensory grounding (13 activities)

5-4-3-2-1 Grounding, Color Hunt, Mindful Eating (Sensory Snack), Glitter Jar (Mind Jar), Texture Walk (Touch Hunt), Sound Map, Smell & Guess, Temperature Check (Hot/Cold), Mindful Seeing (Object Study), Bubble Breathing & Popping, Sensory Walk (Mindful Walking), Cloud Watching, Mindful Handwashing

Movement/yoga (12 activities)

Fortune Wheel Yoga, Dance Party (Freeze Dance), Mindful Walking (Indoor), Tree Pose (Balance Focus), Animal Movement Cards, Progressive Muscle Relaxation (Squeeze & Release), Yoga Flow (Sun Salutation Adaptation), Mindful Stretching, Mindful Marching, Bubble Balloons (Keep It Up), Nature Walk & Notice, Seated Spinal Twist

Sound/listening (9 activities)

Golden Moment (Bell Listening), Mindful Listening (Sounds Around), Chime & Breath, Sound Sorting (Loud/Soft), Silent Moment (Group Stillness), Echo Clapping, Music & Feelings, Whisper Challenge, Mindful Storytime (Listen & Imagine)

Visualization/imagery (8 activities)

Safe Place Visualization, Beach or Forest Journey, Color Breath Visualization, Thought Bubble (Watch Thoughts Pass), Worry Monster Creation, Growing Tree Visualization, Imagine Your Best Self, Star Visualization (Light & Warmth)

Emotion awareness (10 activities)

Feelings Check-In (Emotion Thermometer), Three Good Things, Emotion Charades, Feelings & Body Map, Gratitude Circle, Emotion Weather Report, Mindful of Others (Noticing Kindness), Strengths Spotting, Feelings Flashcards, Emotion Wave (Riding the Feeling)

Body awareness (8 activities)

Body Scan (Calming), Hands & Feet Focus (Trauma-Sensitive Body Awareness), Shoulder & Neck Release, Mindful Posture Check, Heartbeat Awareness, Mindful Standing (Mountain Pose), Face Relaxation (Melt the Tension), Squeeze & Let Go (Fists)

Compassion/kindness (9 activities)

Loving-Kindness for Kids, Kind Words to Self, Compliment Circle, Gratitude Letter (Thank You Note), Heartfulness Practice (Wishing Well), Forgiveness Practice (Let It Go), Noticing Good in Others, Self-Appreciation (One Good Thing About Me), Gratitude Walk

Attention/focus (9 activities)

Mindful Counting, Finger Labyrinths, iSPY (Mindful Observation), Mindful Coloring, Simon Says (Body Attention), Find the Difference (Visual Attention), Mindful Listening to Music, One-Minute Focus Challenge, Mindful Transitions (One Thing at a Time)

Social/group mindfulness (7 activities)

Mindful Greetings, Pass the Squeeze (Group Pulse), Mindful Eye Contact (Partner Gaze), Group Breath (Synchronized Breathing), Mindful Sharing Circle, Noticing Together (Shared Observation), Appreciation Circle (Gratitude for Others)

Transition/reset (6 activities)

30-Second Reset (Quick Breath), Desk Reset (Sit & Breathe), Mindful Line-Up (Waiting Practice), Brain Break (Movement Reset), Quiet Hands (Calm Down Quickly), End-of-Day Reflection

Trauma-Sensitive Practice

Activities marked with a trauma-sensitive note include specific guidance for use with students who may have trauma histories. Key principles: always offer choice, never force eye closure, allow an observer/opt-out role, use invitational language, and avoid practices that require physical touch or body scanning without explicit consent. When in doubt, consult your clinical supervisor.

Three States of Mind: A DBT Framework for Children

Every activity in this guide is tagged with the DBT states of mind it addresses. The DBT framework identifies three states of mind that we all move between throughout the day. This guide uses child-friendly language developed for youth — pairing the clinical DBT term with a concrete metaphor that children can recognize in themselves.

State of Mind	What It Feels Like	Teaching Prompt for Kids
Emotion Mind	Overwhelmed, reactive, impulsive, 'can't think straight', body tense or racing	When your Emotion Mind is in charge, you might feel like a volcano ready to erupt or a deer frozen in headlights. Your feelings are SO BIG that they take over.
Robot Mind (Reasonable Mind)	Detached, analytical, going through the motions, ignoring feelings, 'just the facts'	When your Robot Mind is in charge, you might feel like a computer — running on logic but not noticing how you or others feel. Everything is facts and rules.
Wise Mind	Calm, clear, balanced, intuitive, 'I know what to do', grounded, centered	When your Wise Mind is in charge, you can feel your feelings AND think clearly at the same time. It's like having both your heart and your head working together — that's when you make your best decisions.

How to use these tags: Each activity is labeled with the states of mind it engages most directly. Emotion Mind activities help regulate reactive, feeling-driven states. Robot Mind activities engage logic, structure, and observation. Wise Mind activities practice the integration of both. Look for the purple "Wise Mind Connection" note on each activity card for specific guidance on how the practice moves students toward Wise Mind.

Quick Reference Table

The following table summarizes all activities for quick scanning. Detailed instructions begin on the next page.

ID	Activity	Type	Mind	Grades	Primary Use Case	Duration	Setting	Energy	Group	Materials
B01	Pinwheel Breathing	Breathing	E/W	K-2 / 3-5	Anxiety & Worry	1-3 minutes	Any	Calm	Ind/Grp	Pinwheel per student
B02	Teddy Bear Belly Breathing	Breathing	E/W	K-2 / 3-5	Sleep & Settling	3-5 minutes	Quiet	Calm	Ind/Sm	Stuffed animal or soft object per student
B03	Four-Square (Box) Breathing	Breathing	E/R/W	3-5 / 6-8	Anxiety & Worry	1-3 minutes	Any	Calm	Any	None (optional: drawn square on paper)
B04	Breath Ball (Hoberman Sphere)	Breathing	E/W	K-2 / 3-5 / 6-8	Attention & Focus	1-3 minutes	Any	Calm	Any	Hoberman sphere (breath ball)
B05	Balloon Breathing	Breathing	E/W	K-2 / 3-5	Anxiety & Worry	1-3 minutes	Any	Calm	Any	None
B06	Flower & Candle Breathing	Breathing	E/W	K-2 / 3-5	Anxiety & Worry	1-3 minutes	Any	Calm	Any	None (optional: real flower and candle visual)
B07	Bee Breath (Humming Exhale)	Breathing	E/W	K-2 / 3-5 / 6-8	Anxiety & Worry	1-3 minutes	Any	Calm	Any	None
B08	Count Your Breaths	Breathing	E/R/W	6-8	Attention & Focus	5-10 minutes	Quiet	Focus	Ind/Sm	None
B09	Shape Breathing	Breathing	E/W	K-2 / 3-5 / 6-8	Anxiety & Worry	1-3 minutes	Any	Calm	Any	Printed shapes (triangle, square, star)
B10	Ocean Breath (Whisper Breath)	Breathing	E/W	3-5 / 6-8	Anxiety & Worry	3-5 minutes	Quiet	Calm	Any	None
B11	Rainbow Breathing	Breathing	E/W	K-2 / 3-5	Attention & Focus	1-3 minutes	Any	Calm	Any	None
B12	Feather Breathing	Breathing	E/W	K-2 / 3-5	Anxiety & Worry	1-3 minutes	Any	Calm	Any	Craft feather per student
B13	5-Finger Breathing (Star Fingers)	Breathing	E/W	K-2 / 3-5 / 6-8	Anxiety & Worry	1-3 minutes	Any	Calm	Any	None (own hand)
B14	Snake Breath (Long Slow Exhale)	Breathing	E/W	K-2 / 3-5	Anger & Frustration	1-3 minutes	Any	Calm	Any	None
B15	Belly Breathing with Hand on Heart	Breathing	E/W	3-5 / 6-8	Sadness & Shutdown	3-5 minutes	Quiet	Reflect	Ind/Sm	None
S01	5-4-3-2-1 Grounding	Sensory	E/W	3-5 / 6-8	Anxiety & Worry	1-3 minutes	Any	Focus	Any	None
S02	Color Hunt	Sensory	E/W	K-2 / 3-5 / 6-8	Attention & Focus	3-5 minutes	Out/Cl	Focus	Any	None (optional: paper and pencil)

ID	Activity	Type	Mind	Grades	Primary Use Case	Duration	Setting	Energy	Group	Materials
S03	Mindful Eating (Sensory Snack)	Sensory	E/R/W	K-2 / 3-5 / 6-8	Attention & Focus	3-5 minutes	Any	Focus	Any	A small snack (raisin, cracker, fruit)
S04	Glitter Jar (Mind Jar)	Sensory	E/W	K-2 / 3-5 / 6-8	Anxiety & Worry	3-5 minutes	Any	Calm	Any	Jar, water, glitter, glue
S05	Texture Walk (Touch Hunt)	Sensory	E/W	K-2 / 3-5	Attention & Focus	3-5 minutes	Cl/Out	Active	Any	None
S06	Sound Map	Sensory	E/W	3-5 / 6-8	Attention & Focus	3-5 minutes	Any/Out	Focus	Any	Paper and pencil
S07	Smell & Guess	Sensory	E/W	K-2 / 3-5	Attention & Focus	3-5 minutes	Any	Focus	Small	4-5 scented items (cinnamon, orange, mint, etc.)
S08	Temperature Check (Hot/Cold)	Sensory	E/W	K-2 / 3-5 / 6-8	Anxiety & Worry	1-3 minutes	Any	Focus	Any	Warm and cold objects (warm rice pack, ice pack)
S09	Mindful Seeing (Object Study)	Sensory	E/W	3-5 / 6-8	Attention & Focus	3-5 minutes	Any	Focus	Any	An interesting object (leaf, stone, shell)
S10	Bubble Breathing & Popping	Sensory	E/W	K-2 / 3-5	Hyperactivity & Restlessness	3-5 minutes	Any	Calm	Any	Bubble solution and wand
S11	Sensory Walk (Mindful Walking)	Sensory	E/W	3-5 / 6-8	Hyperactivity & Restlessness	5-10 minutes	Outdoor	Active	Any	None
S12	Cloud Watching	Sensory	E/W	K-2 / 3-5 / 6-8	Attention & Focus	5-10 minutes	Outdoor	Calm	Any	None (a blanket to lie on)
M01	Fortune Wheel Yoga	Movement	E/W	K-2 / 3-5 / 6-8	Hyperactivity & Restlessness	5-10 minutes	Floor	Active	Whole	Online wheel or spinner; yoga pose cards
M02	Dance Party (Freeze Dance)	Movement	E/W	K-2 / 3-5	Hyperactivity & Restlessness	5-10 minutes	Open	Active	Whole	Music and speaker
M03	Mindful Walking (Indoor)	Movement	E/W	3-5 / 6-8	Hyperactivity & Restlessness	3-5 minutes	Cl/Hall	Focus	Sm/Ind	None
M04	Tree Pose (Balance Focus)	Movement	E/R/W	3-5 / 6-8	Attention & Focus	1-3 minutes	Any	Focus	Any	None
M05	Animal Movement Cards	Movement	E/W	K-2 / 3-5	Hyperactivity & Restlessness	3-5 minutes	Floor	Active	Any	Animal movement cards
M06	Progressive Muscle Relaxation (Squeeze & Release)	Movement	E/W	3-5 / 6-8	Anxiety & Worry	5-10 minutes	Quiet	Calm	Any	None

ID	Activity	Type	Mind	Grades	Primary Use Case	Duration	Setting	Energy	Group	Materials
M07	Yoga Flow (Sun Salutation Adaptation)	Movement	E/W	6-8	Anxiety & Worry	5-10 minutes	Floor	Active	Any	Yoga mats (optional)
M08	Mindful Stretching	Movement	E/W	K-2 / 3-5 / 6-8	Hyperactivity & Restlessness	3-5 minutes	Desk/Flr	Calm	Any	None
M09	Mindful Marching	Movement	E/W	K-2 / 3-5	Hyperactivity & Restlessness	1-3 minutes	Open	Active	Whole	None
M10	Bubble Balloons (Keep It Up)	Movement	E/W	K-2 / 3-5	Hyperactivity & Restlessness	3-5 minutes	Open	Active	Whole	Multiple balloons
M11	Nature Walk & Notice	Movement	E/W	K-2 / 3-5 / 6-8	Attention & Focus	10+ minutes	Outdoor	Calm	Any	None (optional: journal)
M12	Seated Spinal Twist	Movement	E/W	3-5 / 6-8	Attention & Focus	1-3 minutes	Desk	Calm	Any	None
L01	Golden Moment (Bell Listening)	Sound	E/W	K-2 / 3-5 / 6-8	Attention & Focus	1-3 minutes	Any	Focus	Any	Bell, tuning fork, or audio bell
L02	Mindful Listening (Sounds Around)	Sound	E/W	K-2 / 3-5 / 6-8	Attention & Focus	3-5 minutes	Any	Focus	Any	None
L03	Chime & Breath	Sound	E/W	K-2 / 3-5 / 6-8	Anxiety & Worry	3-5 minutes	Any	Calm	Any	Chime or singing bowl
L04	Sound Sorting (Loud/Soft)	Sound	E/W	K-2 / 3-5	Attention & Focus	3-5 minutes	Any	Focus	Small	Various sound-making objects
L05	Silent Moment (Group Stillness)	Sound	E/W	3-5 / 6-8	Attention & Focus	1-3 minutes	Any	Focus	Whole	Timer
L06	Echo Clapping	Sound	E/W	K-2 / 3-5	Attention & Focus	1-3 minutes	Any	Focus	Whole	None
L07	Music & Feelings	Sound	E/R/W	3-5 / 6-8	Sadness & Shutdown	5-10 minutes	Quiet	Reflect	Any	Music player, selected tracks
L08	Whisper Challenge	Sound	E/W	K-2 / 3-5	Attention & Focus	3-5 minutes	Any	Focus	Small	None
V01	Safe Place Visualization	Visualization	E/W	3-5 / 6-8	Anxiety & Worry	5-10 minutes	Quiet	Calm	Ind/Sm	None
V02	Beach or Forest Journey	Visualization	E/W	K-2 / 3-5 / 6-8	Anxiety & Worry	5-10 minutes	Quiet	Calm	Any	None (optional: nature sounds)
V03	Color Breath Visualization	Visualization	E/W	K-2 / 3-5 / 6-8	Anxiety & Worry	3-5 minutes	Any	Calm	Any	None

ID	Activity	Type	Mind	Grades	Primary Use Case	Duration	Setting	Energy	Group	Materials
V04	Thought Bubble (Watch Thoughts Pass)	Visualization	E/W	3-5 / 6-8	Anxiety & Worry	3-5 minutes	Quiet	Focus	Ind/Sm	None (optional: paper for drawing)
V05	Worry Monster Creation	Visualization	E/W	K-2 / 3-5	Anxiety & Worry	10+ minutes	Any	Active	Any	Box, craft supplies, scissors
V06	Growing Tree Visualization	Visualization	E/W	K-2 / 3-5	Sadness & Shutdown	3-5 minutes	Any	Calm	Any	None
V07	Imagine Your Best Self	Visualization	E/W	6-8	Sadness & Shutdown	5-10 minutes	Quiet	Reflect	Ind/Sm	None (optional: journal)
V08	Star Visualization (Light & Warmth)	Visualization	E/W	K-2 / 3-5 / 6-8	Anxiety & Worry	3-5 minutes	Quiet	Calm	Any	None
E01	Feelings Check-In (Emotion Thermometer)	Emotion	E/R/W	K-2 / 3-5 / 6-8	Anxiety & Worry	1-3 minutes	Any	Reflect	Any	Emotion thermometer or chart
E02	Three Good Things	Emotion	E/R/W	K-2 / 3-5 / 6-8	Sadness & Shutdown	3-5 minutes	Any	Reflect	Any	None (optional: journal)
E03	Emotion Charades	Emotion	E/W	K-2 / 3-5	General Daily Practice	5-10 minutes	Any	Active	Sm/Whole	Emotion cards
E04	Feelings & Body Map	Emotion	E/R/W	3-5 / 6-8	Anxiety & Worry	5-10 minutes	Any	Reflect	Ind/Sm	Body outline printout, colored pencils
E05	Gratitude Circle	Emotion	E/R/W	K-2 / 3-5 / 6-8	Sadness & Shutdown	5-10 minutes	Any	Reflect	Whole	None
E06	Emotion Weather Report	Emotion	E/W	3-5 / 6-8	Sadness & Shutdown	3-5 minutes	Any	Reflect	Any	None
E07	Mindful of Others (Noticing Kindness)	Emotion	E/W	K-2 / 3-5	Conflict & Peer Issues	5-10 minutes	Any	Reflect	Whole	None
E08	Strengths Spotting	Emotion	E/R/W	3-5 / 6-8	Sadness & Shutdown	5-10 minutes	Any	Reflect	Sm/Whole	None
E09	Feelings Flashcards	Emotion	E/W	K-2 / 3-5	General Daily Practice	3-5 minutes	Any	Reflect	Any	Feelings flashcards (faces)
E10	Emotion Wave (Riding the Feeling)	Emotion	E/W	6-8	Anger & Frustration	3-5 minutes	Quiet	Reflect	Ind/Sm	None
A01	Body Scan (Calming)	Body	E/W	3-5 / 6-8	Anxiety & Worry	5-10 minutes	Quiet	Calm	Any	None (optional: mat)

ID	Activity	Type	Mind	Grades	Primary Use Case	Duration	Setting	Energy	Group	Materials
A02	Hands & Feet Focus (Trauma-Sensitive Body Awareness)	Body	E/W	K-2 / 3-5 / 6-8	Anxiety & Worry	3-5 minutes	Any	Calm	Any	None
A03	Shoulder & Neck Release	Body	E/W	3-5 / 6-8	Anxiety & Worry	3-5 minutes	Desk	Calm	Any	None
A04	Mindful Posture Check	Body	E/W	3-5 / 6-8	Attention & Focus	1-3 minutes	Desk	Focus	Any	None
A05	Heartbeat Awareness	Body	E/W	3-5 / 6-8	Anxiety & Worry	3-5 minutes	Any	Calm	Any	None
A06	Mindful Standing (Mountain Pose)	Body	E/R/W	3-5 / 6-8	Attention & Focus	1-3 minutes	Any	Focus	Any	None
A07	Face Relaxation (Melt the Tension)	Body	E/W	K-2 / 3-5 / 6-8	Anxiety & Worry	3-5 minutes	Any	Calm	Any	None
A08	Squeeze & Let Go (Fists)	Body	E/W	K-2 / 3-5 / 6-8	Anger & Frustration	1-3 minutes	Any	Calm	Any	None
C01	Loving-Kindness for Kids	Compassion	E/R/W	3-5 / 6-8	Sadness & Shutdown	3-5 minutes	Quiet	Reflect	Any	None
C02	Kind Words to Self	Compassion	E/R/W	K-2 / 3-5 / 6-8	Sadness & Shutdown	3-5 minutes	Any	Reflect	Any	None
C03	Compliment Circle	Compassion	E/W	K-2 / 3-5 / 6-8	Conflict & Peer Issues	5-10 minutes	Any	Reflect	Whole	None
C04	Gratitude Letter (Thank You Note)	Compassion	E/R/W	3-5 / 6-8	Sadness & Shutdown	10+ minutes	Any	Reflect	Ind	Paper, pencil, envelope
C05	Heartfulness Practice (Wishing Well)	Compassion	E/W	K-2 / 3-5	Conflict & Peer Issues	3-5 minutes	Any	Reflect	Any	None
C06	Forgiveness Practice (Let It Go)	Compassion	E/W	6-8	Anger & Frustration	5-10 minutes	Quiet	Reflect	Ind/Sm	None (optional: journal)
C07	Noticing Good in Others	Compassion	E/W	3-5 / 6-8	Conflict & Peer Issues	5-10 minutes	Any	Reflect	Any	None
C08	Self-Appreciation (One Good Thing About Me)	Compassion	E/R/W	K-2 / 3-5 / 6-8	Sadness & Shutdown	3-5 minutes	Any	Reflect	Any	None (optional: journal)
F01	Mindful Counting	Attention	E/W	3-5 / 6-8	Attention & Focus	3-5 minutes	Any	Focus	Any	None

ID	Activity	Type	Mind	Grades	Primary Use Case	Duration	Setting	Energy	Group	Materials
F02	Finger Labyrinths	Attention	E/W	K-2 / 3-5 / 6-8	Attention & Focus	3-5 minutes	Any	Focus	Any	Printed finger labyrinth, pencil
F03	iSPY (Mindful Observation)	Attention	E/W	K-2 / 3-5	Attention & Focus	5-10 minutes	Out/CI	Focus	Small	None
F04	Mindful Coloring	Attention	E/W	K-2 / 3-5 / 6-8	Anxiety & Worry	10+ minutes	Any	Calm	Any	Coloring pages, colored pencils or crayons
F05	Simon Says (Body Attention)	Attention	E/W	K-2 / 3-5	Hyperactivity & Restlessness	5-10 minutes	Open	Active	Whole	None
F06	Find the Difference (Visual Attention)	Attention	E/W	K-2 / 3-5	Attention & Focus	3-5 minutes	Any	Focus	Any	Find-the-difference pictures
F07	Mindful Listening to Music	Attention	E/R/W	3-5 / 6-8	Attention & Focus	5-10 minutes	Any	Calm	Any	Music player, instrumental track
F08	One-Minute Focus Challenge	Attention	E/W	3-5 / 6-8	Attention & Focus	1-3 minutes	Any	Focus	Any	Timer, small object (stone, coin)
G01	Mindful Greetings	Social	E/W	K-2 / 3-5 / 6-8	General Daily Practice	1-3 minutes	Any	Reflect	Whole	None
G02	Pass the Squeeze (Group Pulse)	Social	E/W	K-2 / 3-5 / 6-8	General Daily Practice	3-5 minutes	Any	Calm	Whole	None
G03	Mindful Eye Contact (Partner Gaze)	Social	E/W	3-5 / 6-8	Conflict & Peer Issues	1-3 minutes	Any	Reflect	Pairs	None
G04	Group Breath (Synchronized Breathing)	Social	E/W	K-2 / 3-5 / 6-8	Anxiety & Worry	3-5 minutes	Any	Calm	Whole	None
G05	Mindful Sharing Circle	Social	E/R/W	3-5 / 6-8	Sadness & Shutdown	5-10 minutes	Any	Reflect	Whole	A talking object
G06	Noticing Together (Shared Observation)	Social	E/W	K-2 / 3-5	Attention & Focus	3-5 minutes	Any	Focus	Pr/Sm	An object (leaf, stone, photo)
G07	Appreciation Circle (Gratitude for Others)	Social	E/R/W	3-5 / 6-8	Conflict & Peer Issues	5-10 minutes	Any	Reflect	Whole	None
T01	30-Second Reset (Quick Breath)	Transition	E/W	K-2 / 3-5 / 6-8	Transition Difficulty	Under 1 minute	Any	Calm	Any	None
T02	Desk Reset (Sit & Breathe)	Transition	E/W	3-5 / 6-8	Transition Difficulty	1-3 minutes	Desk	Calm	Any	None
T03	Mindful Line-Up (Waiting Practice)	Transition	E/W	K-2 / 3-5 / 6-8	Transition Difficulty	1-3 minutes	Any	Calm	Whole	None

ID	Activity	Type	Mind	Grades	Primary Use Case	Duration	Setting	Energy	Group	Materials
T04	Brain Break (Movement Reset)	Transition	E/W	K-2 / 3-5 / 6-8	Hyperactivity & Restlessness	1-3 minutes	Open/Dsk	Active	Whole	None
T05	Quiet Hands (Calm Down Quickly)	Transition	E/W	K-2 / 3-5	Anger & Frustration	1-3 minutes	Any	Calm	Any	None
T06	End-of-Day Reflection	Transition	E/R/W	3-5 / 6-8	General Daily Practice	3-5 minutes	Any	Reflect	Any	None (optional: journal)
P01	Mindful Storytime (Listen & Imagine)	Sound	E/R/W	K-2 / 3-5	Attention & Focus	10+ minutes	Quiet	Calm	Any	A storybook
P02	Breathing Buddy (Object on Belly)	Breathing	E/W	K-2 / 3-5	Anxiety & Worry	3-5 minutes	Quiet	Calm	Ind/Sm	Small stuffed animal or beanbag per student
P03	Noticing the Pause (Between Breath)	Breathing	E/W	6-8	Attention & Focus	3-5 minutes	Quiet	Focus	Ind/Sm	None
P04	Mindful Handwashing	Sensory	E/W	K-2 / 3-5 / 6-8	General Daily Practice	1-3 minutes	Any	Focus	Any	Sink, soap, water
P05	Gratitude Walk	Compassion	E/R/W	3-5 / 6-8	Sadness & Shutdown	10+ minutes	Outdoor	Calm	Any	None (optional: journal)
P06	Mindful Transitions (One Thing at a Time)	Attention	E/W	3-5 / 6-8	Transition Difficulty	1-3 minutes	Any	Focus	Any	None

Breathing

17 activities in this category.

BREATHING · GRADES K-2/3-5 · 1-3 MINUTES · CALMING

Pinwheel Breathing

Activity B01

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5	DURATION 1-3 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Individual or group
MATERIALS Pinwheel per student	ENERGY LEVEL Calming

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Give each student a pinwheel.
- 2 Have them take long, slow breaths to spin the pinwheel slowly.
- 3 Then try short, quick breaths, and finally normal breathing.
- 4 Ask how each type of breath felt different.

Adaptations. K-2: focus on making it spin. 6-8: add counting (inhale 4, exhale 6).

Wise Mind Connection. Calms the Emotion Mind's fight-or-flight response and brings attention to the present, opening the door to Wise Mind.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; no closing eyes required.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Extended exhalation activates the parasympathetic nervous system, slowing heart rate and reducing anxiety.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Before tests, after transitions, during anxiety spikes.

Source: NAMI Mindfulness Activities (<https://www.nami.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/11/Mindfulness-Elementary.pdf>)

BREATHING · GRADES K-2/3-5 · 3-5 MINUTES · CALMING

Teddy Bear Belly Breathing

Activity B02

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5	DURATION 3-5 minutes
SETTING Quiet/private	GROUP SIZE Individual or small group
MATERIALS Stuffed animal or soft object per student	ENERGY LEVEL Calming

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Have each student lie down and place a stuffed animal on their belly.
- 2 Breathe in slowly and watch the animal rise.
- 3 Breathe out slowly and watch it fall.
- 4 Repeat for several rounds, as if rocking the animal to sleep.

Adaptations. K-2: tell a story about putting the bear to sleep. 6-8: add breath counting.

Wise Mind Connection. Soothes the Emotion Mind by activating the body's calming system. The physical feedback (teddy bear rising) bridges Robot Mind awareness with emotional regulation, building Wise Mind.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. No touch from educator; student places object on own belly. Eyes can stay open.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Diaphragmatic breathing with visual feedback teaches slow, deep breathing and grounds attention in the body.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Bedtime routines, after high-energy activities, during anxiety.

Source: Mindful.org (<https://www.mindful.org/mindfulness-for-kids/>)

BREATHING · GRADES 3-5/6-8 · 1-3 MINUTES · CALMING

Four-Square (Box) Breathing

Activity B03

EMOTION MIND

ROBOT MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 1-3 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None (optional: drawn square on paper)	ENERGY LEVEL Calming

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Trace or visualize a square: inhale for 4 counts (up the left side).
- 2 Hold for 4 counts (across the top).
- 3 Exhale for 4 counts (down the right side).
- 4 Hold for 4 counts (across the bottom). Repeat 3-5 times.

Adaptations. 3-5: trace a drawn square with a finger. 6-8: increase to 5 or 6 counts.

Wise Mind Connection. The structured counting appeals to Robot Mind while the breathing itself calms Emotion Mind — the two working together is Wise Mind in action.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; can trace a square with a finger for grounding.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Equal-ratio breathing with breath holds regulates the autonomic nervous system and improves focus.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Before tests, during conflict escalation, before presentations.

Source: Mindful.org (<https://www.mindful.org/mindfulness-for-kids/>)

BREATHING · GRADES K-2/3-5/6-8 · 1-3 MINUTES · CALMING

Breath Ball (Hoberman Sphere)

Activity B04

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 1-3 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS Hoberman sphere (breath ball)	ENERGY LEVEL Calming

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Hold the breath ball in front of the belly.
- 2 Expand it as you inhale (belly expands).
- 3 Optionally pause at the top.
- 4 Contract it as you exhale. Repeat several rounds, counting rhythmically.

Adaptations. K-2: let students take turns leading with the ball. 6-8: sync the whole group to one ball.

Wise Mind Connection. The visual expansion/contraction of the sphere mirrors the shift from Emotion Mind's intensity to Wise Mind's balance.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Visual focus on the ball; no closed eyes needed.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Visual-auditory-kinesthetic synchronization of breath builds breath awareness and group attunement.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Classroom transitions, group centering, focus resets.

Source: Mindful.org (<https://www.mindful.org/mindfulness-for-kids/>)

BREATHING · GRADES K-2/3-5 · 1-3 MINUTES · CALMING

Balloon Breathing

Activity B05

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5	DURATION 1-3 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Calming

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Place hands on belly like a balloon.
- 2 Breathe in and feel the belly balloon expand.
- 3 Breathe out and feel it deflate.
- 4 Repeat slowly 5-10 times.

Adaptations. K-2: pretend to blow up a giant balloon. 6-8: add a count (in 4, out 6).

Wise Mind Connection. The slow exhale activates the calming system, moving the student out of Emotion Mind reactivity and into a Wise Mind state.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; imagine the balloon or place hands on belly.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Diaphragmatic breathing with tactile/visual feedback slows respiration and calms the nervous system.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Quick calming, before seated work.

Source: Adapted from Mindful Schools practices (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

BREATHING · GRADES K-2/3-5 · 1-3 MINUTES · CALMING

Flower & Candle Breathing

Activity B06

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5	DURATION 1-3 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None (optional: real flower and candle visual)	ENERGY LEVEL Calming

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Imagine holding a flower in one hand and a candle in the other.
- 2 Smell the flower: breathe in slowly through the nose.
- 3 Blow out the candle: breathe out slowly through the mouth.
- 4 Repeat 5 times.

Adaptations. K-2: use real or paper flower/candle props. 6-8: add counting.

Wise Mind Connection. Engages both Robot Mind (counting the rhythm) and Emotion Mind (feeling the breath), practicing their integration into Wise Mind.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. No real flame; use imagination or a picture. Eyes-open.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Imagery-assisted breathing extends exhalation and engages the parasympathetic response.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Young children, anxiety, before quiet activities.

Source: Adapted from classroom mindfulness practices (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

BREATHING · GRADES K-2/3-5/6-8 · 1-3 MINUTES · CALMING

Bee Breath (Humming Exhale)

Activity B07

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 1-3 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Calming

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Inhale through the nose.
- 2 Exhale with a gentle humming sound like a bee.
- 3 Notice the vibration in the lips and face.
- 4 Repeat 5-10 rounds.

Adaptations. K-2: make it a game with bee fingers flying. 6-8: try with eyes closed (optional) and notice the buzz.

Wise Mind Connection. The vibration and extended exhale calm the Emotion Mind. The focus required invites Wise Mind awareness.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Humming is eyes-open and non-invasive; students choose volume.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Extended humming exhalation stimulates the vagus nerve and produces a calming effect; the vibration provides sensory grounding.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Before tests, during conflict cooldown, group calming.

Source: Adapted from yoga and mindfulness-in-schools research (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

BREATHING · GRADES 6-8 · 5-10 MINUTES · FOCUSING

Count Your Breaths

Activity B08

EMOTION MIND ROBOT MIND WISE MIND

GRADES 6-8	DURATION 5-10 minutes
SETTING Quiet/private	GROUP SIZE Individual or small group
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Focusing

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Sit comfortably and notice the breath.
- 2 Count each exhale silently: 1, 2, 3... up to 10.
- 3 If the mind wanders, return to 1 and start again.
- 4 Continue for several rounds.

Adaptations. 6-8: start with 3 minutes and build up. Offer a timer option.

Wise Mind Connection. Counting breaths engages Robot Mind's precision while the breathing itself soothes Emotion Mind — a direct Wise Mind practice.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Offer eyes-open option; frame as noticing, not emptying the mind.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Counted breath meditation builds sustained attention and metacognitive awareness of mind-wandering.

Evidence basis. Research-supported program component

When to use. Middle schoolers, sustained focus practice, test prep.

Source: Mindful.org (Count Your Breaths, Dr. Mark Bertin) (<https://www.mindful.org/mindfulness-for-kids/>)

BREATHING · GRADES K-2/3-5/6-8 · 1-3 MINUTES · CALMING

Shape Breathing

Activity B09

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 1-3 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS Printed shapes (triangle, square, star)	ENERGY LEVEL Calming

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Trace a shape with a finger: triangle (3 sides), square (4), star (5).
- 2 Inhale along one side, exhale along the next.
- 3 Continue around the shape for several rounds.
- 4 Notice how the breathing slows.

Adaptations. K-2: use the simplest shape. 6-8: choose a shape and explain why it helps.

Wise Mind Connection. Tracing a shape while breathing uses Robot Mind structure to regulate Emotion Mind, arriving at Wise Mind.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; visual tracing is grounding.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Combining visual-motor tracing with paced breathing anchors attention and regulates breathing rhythm.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Quick resets, before tests, desk-based.

Source: Adapted from classroom mindfulness and SEL resources (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

BREATHING · GRADES 3-5/6-8 · 3-5 MINUTES · CALMING

Ocean Breath (Whisper Breath)

Activity B10

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 3-5 minutes
SETTING Quiet/private	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Calming

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Inhale through the nose.
- 2 Exhale slowly with a soft 'haaa' sound, like ocean waves.
- 3 Keep the sound gentle and steady.
- 4 Continue for several rounds, imagining waves.

Adaptations. 3-5: pair with a wave visual. 6-8: notice the calming effect of the sound.

Wise Mind Connection. The ocean sound and slow breathing activate the calming system, shifting from Emotion Mind reactivity to Wise Mind presence.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Soft sound; eyes-open option.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Auditory feedback from the breath extends exhalation and provides a soothing, repetitive focus.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Calming, before sleep routines, group settling.

Source: Adapted from yoga-in-schools practices (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

BREATHING · GRADES K-2/3-5 · 1-3 MINUTES · CALMING

Rainbow Breathing

Activity B11

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5	DURATION 1-3 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Calming

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Reach arms overhead as you inhale (painting the rainbow up).
- 2 Lower arms slowly as you exhale (painting it down).
- 3 Repeat for each color of the rainbow.
- 4 End with a big stretch.

Adaptations. K-2: name a color each time. 6-8: add a kind thought per color.

Wise Mind Connection. The multi-sensory nature (color + movement + breath) engages both emotional and logical pathways, supporting Wise Mind integration.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; arm movements are optional.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Movement-coordinated breathing engages the body and breath together, building focus and calm.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Morning meeting, transitions, energy resets.

Source: Adapted from classroom mindfulness resources (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

BREATHING · GRADES K-2/3-5 · 1-3 MINUTES · CALMING

Feather Breathing

Activity B12

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5	DURATION 1-3 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS Craft feather per student	ENERGY LEVEL Calming

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Hold a feather in front of the face.
- 2 Breathe in through the nose.
- 3 Breathe out slowly and see how long the feather floats.
- 4 Try to keep it in the air with gentle breaths.

Adaptations. K-2: make it a game. 6-8: count how long the feather stays up.

Wise Mind Connection. The visual feedback of the feather moving engages Robot Mind observation while calming Emotion Mind through slow breathing.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; holding the feather is grounding.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Visual feedback from the feather extends exhalation and sustains attention on the breath.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Young children, anxiety, quick calming.

Source: Adapted from classroom mindfulness resources (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

BREATHING · GRADES K-2/3-5/6-8 · 1-3 MINUTES · CALMING

5-Finger Breathing (Star Fingers)

Activity B13

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 1-3 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None (own hand)	ENERGY LEVEL Calming

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Hold up one hand like a star.
- 2 Trace up each finger with the other hand's index finger: inhale.
- 3 Trace down each finger: exhale.
- 4 Continue around all five fingers.

Adaptations. K-2: count the fingers. 6-8: pair with a calming word per finger.

Wise Mind Connection. Using the hand as an anchor combines tactile grounding (Robot Mind) with emotional calming (Emotion Mind), fostering Wise Mind.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Self-contained; eyes-open; no touch from others.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Tactile-visual tracing with breath pacing provides a portable, self-directed calming tool.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Desk-based, before tests, self-regulation.

Source: Adapted from trauma-informed mindfulness practices (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

BREATHING · GRADES K-2/3-5 · 1-3 MINUTES · CALMING

Snake Breath (Long Slow Exhale)

Activity B14

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5	DURATION 1-3 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Calming

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Inhale through the nose.
- 2 Exhale slowly through the mouth with a gentle 'sssss' snake sound.
- 3 Make the exhale as long as possible.
- 4 Repeat 5 times.

Adaptations. K-2: slither like a snake. 6-8: notice the calming effect of the long exhale.

Wise Mind Connection. The playful hissing exhale releases Emotion Mind tension while the structure of the activity invites Wise Mind.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; playful and non-invasive.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Long, slow exhalation activates the parasympathetic nervous system and reduces arousal.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Anger, frustration, quick calming.

Source: Adapted from classroom mindfulness resources (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

BREATHING · GRADES 3-5/6-8 · 3-5 MINUTES · REFLECTIVE

Belly Breathing with Hand on Heart

Activity B15

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 3-5 minutes
SETTING Quiet/private	GROUP SIZE Individual or small group
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Reflective

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Sit comfortably and place one hand on the belly, one on the heart.
- 2 Breathe into the belly, feeling the hand rise.
- 3 Feel the heartbeat under the other hand.
- 4 Breathe slowly for several rounds, offering yourself calm.

Adaptations. 3-5: add a kind phrase. 6-8: notice the steadiness of the heartbeat.

Wise Mind Connection. Combining physical sensation (belly) with emotional connection (heart) directly practices the integration that defines Wise Mind.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Self-touch only; frame as self-kindness. Eyes-open option.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Combining diaphragmatic breathing with self-soothing touch (self-compassion) calms the nervous system and reduces self-criticism.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Sadness, self-criticism, anxiety, end of day.

Source: Adapted from Mindful.org kindness meditation (<https://www.mindful.org/mindfulness-for-kids/>)

BREATHING · GRADES K-2/3-5 · 3-5 MINUTES · CALMING

Breathing Buddy (Object on Belly)

Activity P02

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5	DURATION 3-5 minutes
SETTING Quiet/private	GROUP SIZE Individual or small group
MATERIALS Small stuffed animal or beanbag per student	ENERGY LEVEL Calming

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Lie down and place a small object on the belly.
- 2 Breathe in and watch it rise.
- 3 Breathe out and watch it fall.
- 4 Continue for several rounds.

Adaptations. K-2: use a favorite stuffed animal. 6-8: add counting.

Wise Mind Connection. The breathing buddy provides tactile feedback that bridges Robot Mind (noticing the object) and Emotion Mind (feeling the calm) — Wise Mind.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; self-placed object; non-invasive.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Visual feedback from the rising/falling object teaches diaphragmatic breathing and builds body awareness.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Anxiety, calming, young children, before sleep.

Source: Adapted from Mindful.org belly breathing (<https://www.mindful.org/mindfulness-for-kids/>)

BREATHING · GRADES 6-8 · 3-5 MINUTES · FOCUSING

Noticing the Pause (Between Breath)

Activity P03

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES 6-8	DURATION 3-5 minutes
SETTING Quiet/private	GROUP SIZE Individual or small group
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Focusing

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Breathe naturally and notice the breath.
- 2 Notice the small pause at the top of the inhale.
- 3 Notice the small pause at the bottom of the exhale.
- 4 Rest in the pauses without holding the breath.

Adaptations. 6-8: start with 2 minutes and build up.

Wise Mind Connection. Noticing the pause between thoughts is a direct Wise Mind practice: observing the space where neither Emotion Mind nor Robot Mind dominates.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; noticing, not forcing pauses; non-invasive.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Noticing natural pauses in the breath builds sustained attention and present-moment awareness.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Middle schoolers, attention practice, advanced calming.

Source: Adapted from mindfulness meditation practices (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

Sensory grounding

13 activities in this category.

SENSORY GROUNDING · GRADES 3-5/6-8 · 1-3 MINUTES · FOCUSING

5-4-3-2-1 Grounding

Activity S01

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 1-3 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Focusing

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Name 5 things you can see.
- 2 Name 4 things you can hear.
- 3 Name 3 things you can feel (touch).
- 4 Name 2 things you can smell. Name 1 thing you can taste (or imagine tasting).

Adaptations. 3-5: simplify to 3-2-1. 6-8: write them down.

Wise Mind Connection. Grounding in the five senses pulls attention away from Emotion Mind spiraling and into present-moment Wise Mind awareness.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; focus on external senses, not internal body, which is safer for trauma.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Orienting to external sensory input interrupts anxious rumination and brings attention to the present environment.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Anxiety, panic, transitions, overwhelm.

Source: Adapted from grounding techniques in trauma-informed care (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

SENSORY GROUNDING · GRADES K-2/3-5/6-8 · 3-5 MINUTES · FOCUSING

Color Hunt

Activity S02

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 3-5 minutes
SETTING Outdoors or classroom	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None (optional: paper and pencil)	ENERGY LEVEL Focusing

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Choose any color.
- 2 Walk around and find everything you can see that is that color.
- 3 Write down or name each item.
- 4 Notice how many things you find.

Adaptations. K-2: hunt as a group. 6-8: time it or find shades of the color.

Wise Mind Connection. The visual search task engages Robot Mind's observational power to regulate Emotion Mind, arriving at Wise Mind presence.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; movement-based; fully optional participation.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Visual scanning and orienting to the environment builds present-moment attention and curiosity.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Attention building, outdoor activities, transitions.

Source: NAMI Mindfulness Activities (<https://www.nami.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/11/Mindfulness-Elementary.pdf>)

SENSORY GROUNDING · GRADES K-2/3-5/6-8 · 3-5 MINUTES · FOCUSING

Mindful Eating (Sensory Snack)

Activity S03

EMOTION MIND

ROBOT MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 3-5 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS A small snack (raisin, cracker, fruit)	ENERGY LEVEL Focusing

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Hold the snack and look at it closely: notice color, texture, shape.
- 2 Smell it: notice the scent.
- 3 Place it on the tongue and notice the texture before chewing.
- 4 Chew slowly and notice the taste and how it changes.

Adaptations. K-2: use a familiar snack. 6-8: describe in writing.

Wise Mind Connection. Mindful eating requires Robot Mind's analytical noticing (texture, flavor) while honoring Emotion Mind's experience — a Wise Mind practice.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; eating is grounding; respect food sensitivities.

Cautions. Food allergies — verify snack safety.

Why it works. Multi-sensory attention to eating builds present-moment awareness and slows automatic behavior.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Attention practice, after lunch, calm transitions.

Source: Mindful.org (<https://www.mindful.org/mindfulness-for-kids/>)

SENSORY GROUNDING · GRADES K-2/3-5/6-8 · 3-5 MINUTES · CALMING

Glitter Jar (Mind Jar)

Activity S04

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 3-5 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS Jar, water, glitter, glue	ENERGY LEVEL Calming

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Shake the glitter jar and watch the glitter swirl.
- 2 Explain that the swirling glitter is like a busy mind.
- 3 Sit and watch as the glitter slowly settles.
- 4 Notice how the mind settles as the jar settles.

Adaptations. K-2: make it a craft activity. 6-8: discuss the metaphor.

Wise Mind Connection. Watching the glitter settle mirrors the settling of Emotion Mind's storm. The visual metaphor helps students see Wise Mind emerging.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; visual focus; no closed eyes.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Visual fixation on a slow-settling object provides a calming anchor and models the settling of thoughts.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Anxiety, anger, overwhelm, classroom calming corner.

Source: Mindful.org (<https://www.mindful.org/mindfulness-for-kids/>)

SENSORY GROUNDING · GRADES K-2/3-5 · 3-5 MINUTES · ACTIVATING

Texture Walk (Touch Hunt)

Activity S05

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5	DURATION 3-5 minutes
SETTING Classroom or outdoors	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Activating

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Walk around the room or outside.
- 2 Find and touch things with different textures: smooth, rough, soft, hard.
- 3 Describe how each feels.
- 4 Collect 4-5 different textures.

Adaptations. K-2: guide them to specific textures. 6-8: record and categorize.

Wise Mind Connection. Tactile grounding engages Robot Mind's sensory processing to calm Emotion Mind, creating a bridge to Wise Mind.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Students touch objects, not people; eyes-open.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Tactile exploration grounds attention in the present and builds sensory vocabulary.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Attention building, movement break, sensory exploration.

Source: Adapted from classroom mindfulness resources (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

SENSORY GROUNDING · GRADES 3-5/6-8 · 3-5 MINUTES · FOCUSING

Sound Map

Activity S06

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 3-5 minutes
SETTING Any (outdoors ideal)	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS Paper and pencil	ENERGY LEVEL Focusing

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Sit quietly and listen for sounds.
- 2 Draw a map of where each sound comes from (front, behind, left, right).
- 3 Listen for distant and near sounds.
- 4 Notice when new sounds appear.

Adaptations. 3-5: use symbols instead of words. 6-8: note the type of sound.

Wise Mind Connection. Creating a map of sounds uses Robot Mind's organizing ability while opening Emotion Mind to the present — a Wise Mind activity.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; listening outward, not inward.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Auditory orienting and mapping builds sustained attention and present-moment awareness.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Outdoor learning, attention practice, calming.

Source: Adapted from nature mindfulness practices (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

SENSORY GROUNDING · GRADES K-2/3-5 · 3-5 MINUTES · FOCUSING

Smell & Guess

Activity S07

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5	DURATION 3-5 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Small group
MATERIALS 4-5 scented items (cinnamon, orange, mint, etc.)	ENERGY LEVEL Focusing

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Place scented items in covered containers.
- 2 Have students smell each one and guess what it is.
- 3 Describe the scent in one word.
- 4 Notice which smells they like or dislike.

Adaptations. K-2: use familiar scents. 6-8: discuss memories tied to scents.

Wise Mind Connection. The guessing game engages Robot Mind curiosity while the sensory experience grounds Emotion Mind, supporting Wise Mind.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; smelling is grounding; check for sensitivities.

Cautions. Scent sensitivities or allergies.

Why it works. Olfactory grounding engages a powerful sense linked to memory and emotion, anchoring attention in the present.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Sensory exploration, attention practice, group activities.

Source: Adapted from sensory-based mindfulness activities (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

SENSORY GROUNDING · GRADES K-2/3-5/6-8 · 1-3 MINUTES · FOCUSING

Temperature Check (Hot/Cold)

Activity S08

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 1-3 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS Warm and cold objects (warm rice pack, ice pack)	ENERGY LEVEL Focusing

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Hold or touch a warm object and notice the warmth.
- 2 Then touch a cool object and notice the difference.
- 3 Describe how each feels.
- 4 Notice the temperature change on the skin.

Adaptations. K-2: name the feeling. 6-8: discuss how temperature affects mood.

Wise Mind Connection. Noticing temperature shifts uses Robot Mind observation to bring awareness to the body's state, moving toward Wise Mind.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. No extreme temperatures; brief contact only; eyes-open.

Cautions. Skin sensitivities; use mild temperatures only.

Why it works. Temperature contrast provides strong sensory grounding, redirecting attention from anxiety to present sensation.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Anxiety, dissociation, quick grounding.

Source: Adapted from trauma-informed grounding (TIPP) (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

SENSORY GROUNDING · GRADES 3-5/6-8 · 3-5 MINUTES · FOCUSING

Mindful Seeing (Object Study)

Activity S09

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 3-5 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS An interesting object (leaf, stone, shell)	ENERGY LEVEL Focusing

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Choose an object and hold it.
- 2 Look at it as if seeing it for the first time.
- 3 Notice colors, patterns, textures, shapes.
- 4 Turn it over and notice new details.

Adaptations. 3-5: describe it to a partner. 6-8: sketch it in detail.

Wise Mind Connection. Detailed visual observation calms the Emotion Mind by anchoring in the present, opening space for Wise Mind.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; visual focus.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Sustained visual attention to a single object builds concentration and present-moment awareness.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Attention practice, calm transitions, individual work.

Source: Adapted from classroom mindfulness resources (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

SENSORY GROUNDING · GRADES K-2/3-5 · 3-5 MINUTES · CALMING

Bubble Breathing & Popping

Activity S10

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5	DURATION 3-5 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS Bubble solution and wand	ENERGY LEVEL Calming

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Blow bubbles slowly with deep breaths.
- 2 Watch them float and notice their colors.
- 3 Gently pop them one at a time.
- 4 Notice how the breath controls the bubbles.

Adaptations. K-2: make it a game. 6-8: notice the impermanence of each bubble.

Wise Mind Connection. The combination of breath and visual tracking engages both logical and emotional pathways, practicing Wise Mind integration.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; playful and non-invasive.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Breath control with visual feedback from bubbles extends exhalation and provides a calming visual anchor.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Young children, high energy, calming corner.

Source: Adapted from classroom mindfulness resources (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

SENSORY GROUNDING · GRADES 3-5/6-8 · 5-10 MINUTES · ACTIVATING

Sensory Walk (Mindful Walking)

Activity S11

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 5-10 minutes
SETTING Outdoors	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Activating

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Walk slowly and silently.
- 2 Notice what you see, hear, smell, and feel under your feet.
- 3 Pause and name one thing from each sense.
- 4 Continue walking with awareness.

Adaptations. 3-5: use a guided checklist. 6-8: journal after.

Wise Mind Connection. Walking with sensory awareness uses Robot Mind's noticing to regulate Emotion Mind, arriving at Wise Mind presence.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; movement-based; fully optional.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Multi-sensory walking meditation builds present-moment awareness and channels physical energy.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Outdoor activities, high energy, attention building.

Source: Adapted from nature mindfulness practices (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

SENSORY GROUNDING · GRADES K-2/3-5/6-8 · 5-10 MINUTES · CALMING

Cloud Watching

Activity S12

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 5-10 minutes
SETTING Outdoors	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None (a blanket to lie on)	ENERGY LEVEL Calming

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Lie or sit and look up at the clouds.
- 2 Notice their shapes, movement, and speed.
- 3 Watch how they change as they drift.
- 4 Share what shapes you see.

Adaptations. K-2: find animal shapes. 6-8: notice impermanence.

Wise Mind Connection. The open-ended observation of clouds calms Emotion Mind reactivity and invites the spacious, accepting quality of Wise Mind.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; lying down is optional (can sit).

Cautions. None

Why it works. Relaxed visual attention to slow-moving natural phenomena builds sustained awareness and calm.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Outdoor activities, calm practice, anxiety.

Source: Adapted from nature mindfulness practices (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

SENSORY GROUNDING · GRADES K-2/3-5/6-8 · 1-3 MINUTES · FOCUSING

Mindful Handwashing

Activity P04

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 1-3 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS Sink, soap, water	ENERGY LEVEL Focusing

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Turn on the water and notice the temperature.
- 2 Feel the soap between the hands.
- 3 Notice the sensation of rubbing and rinsing.
- 4 Feel the towel drying the hands.

Adaptations. K-2: describe each step. 6-8: notice the temperature and texture in detail.

Wise Mind Connection. Mindful handwashing uses Robot Mind's routine to ground Emotion Mind, a Wise Mind daily-life practice.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; tactile; non-invasive; built into routine.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Bringing mindful attention to a routine activity builds present-moment awareness in daily life.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Routine activities, transitions, sensory grounding.

Source: Adapted from everyday mindfulness practices (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

Movement/yoga

12 activities in this category.

MOVEMENT/YOGA · GRADES K-2/3-5/6-8 · 5-10 MINUTES · ACTIVATING

Fortune Wheel Yoga

Activity M01

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 5-10 minutes
SETTING Floor/movement space	GROUP SIZE Whole classroom
MATERIALS Online wheel or spinner; yoga pose cards	ENERGY LEVEL Activating

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Create a fortune wheel with a yoga pose or movement in each section.
- 2 A student spins the wheel.
- 3 The whole class practices the selected pose together.
- 4 Repeat several times.

Adaptations. K-2: use animal poses. 6-8: hold poses longer and add breath.

Wise Mind Connection. Movement releases Emotion Mind tension while the mindful holding of poses requires Wise Mind attention to the body.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Movement-based; no touch; students choose their own level of participation.

Cautions. Physical limitations — offer seated alternatives.

Why it works. Yoga poses build body awareness, self-regulation, and physical energy release; gamification increases engagement.

Evidence basis. Research-supported program component

When to use. Movement breaks, classroom energy, group practice.

Source: NAMI Mindfulness Activities (<https://www.nami.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/11/Mindfulness-Elementary.pdf>)

MOVEMENT/YOGA · GRADES K-2/3-5 · 5-10 MINUTES · ACTIVATING

Dance Party (Freeze Dance)

Activity M02

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5	DURATION 5-10 minutes
SETTING Open space	GROUP SIZE Whole classroom
MATERIALS Music and speaker	ENERGY LEVEL Activating

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Choose an upbeat dance song.
- 2 Play the music and dance freely.
- 3 When the music stops, freeze in place and notice the body.
- 4 Resume when the music starts.

Adaptations. K-2: use simple dances (Chicken Dance). 6-8: let students choose songs.

Wise Mind Connection. Freeing the body from Emotion Mind's pent-up energy, then noticing the shift, practices the Wise Mind skill of observing without judgment.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Movement-based; no touch; students can opt to watch.

Cautions. Physical limitations — offer seated dancing.

Why it works. Aerobic movement releases physical tension and endorphins; the freeze element builds impulse control and body awareness.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. High energy, mood lifting, movement breaks.

Source: NAMI Mindfulness Activities (<https://www.nami.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/11/Mindfulness-Elementary.pdf>)

MOVEMENT/YOGA · GRADES 3-5/6-8 · 3-5 MINUTES · FOCUSING

Mindful Walking (Indoor)

Activity M03

EMOTION MIND WISE MIND

GRADES 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 3-5 minutes
SETTING Classroom or hallway	GROUP SIZE Small group or individual
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Focusing

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Walk slowly in a line or circle.
- 2 Notice the sensation of each foot lifting and placing down.
- 3 Feel the weight shift from heel to toe.
- 4 Walk in silence, paying attention to the body.

Adaptations. 3-5: walk to a slow count. 6-8: walk with eyes on a point ahead.

Wise Mind Connection. Walking with attention to sensation bridges Robot Mind awareness with Emotion Mind's experience, cultivating Wise Mind.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; movement-based; non-invasive.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Slow walking meditation builds body awareness, sustained attention, and channels restless energy.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Restlessness, attention practice, hallway transitions.

Source: Adapted from mindfulness-in-schools practices (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

MOVEMENT/YOGA · GRADES 3-5/6-8 · 1-3 MINUTES · FOCUSING

Tree Pose (Balance Focus)

Activity M04

EMOTION MIND

ROBOT MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 1-3 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Focusing

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Stand on one leg and place the other foot on the calf or inner thigh.
- 2 Find a fixed point to focus the eyes.
- 3 Hold the pose and breathe.
- 4 Switch sides and repeat.

Adaptations. 3-5: use a wall for support. 6-8: close eyes briefly (optional) to test balance.

Wise Mind Connection. Balancing requires Robot Mind's focus on the body while the emotional calm of the pose soothes Emotion Mind — a Wise Mind integration.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open (soft gaze for balance); offer a wall or chair for support.

Cautions. Balance issues — provide support option.

Why it works. Balancing poses require sustained attention and build proprioceptive awareness and focus.

Evidence basis. Research-supported program component

When to use. Attention building, focus practice, movement breaks.

Source: Adapted from yoga-in-schools research (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

MOVEMENT/YOGA · GRADES K-2/3-5 · 3-5 MINUTES · ACTIVATING

Animal Movement Cards

Activity M05

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5	DURATION 3-5 minutes
SETTING Floor/movement space	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS Animal movement cards	ENERGY LEVEL Activating

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Draw an animal movement card.
- 2 Move like that animal: stretch like a cat, hop like a frog, etc.
- 3 Notice how the body feels in each position.
- 4 Switch cards and try a new animal.

Adaptations. K-2: add animal sounds. 6-8: hold each pose for 3 breaths.

Wise Mind Connection. The playfulness engages Emotion Mind while the animal poses require Robot Mind's body awareness, fostering Wise Mind.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Movement-based; no touch; self-paced.

Cautions. Physical limitations — offer seated alternatives.

Why it works. Imaginative movement builds body awareness, motor control, and engagement through play.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Young children, movement breaks, energy release.

Source: Adapted from classroom mindfulness resources (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

MOVEMENT/YOGA · GRADES 3-5/6-8 · 5-10 MINUTES · CALMING

Progressive Muscle Relaxation (Squeeze & Release)

Activity M06

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 5-10 minutes
SETTING Quiet/private	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Calming

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Starting with the hands: squeeze the fists tight for 5 seconds.
- 2 Release and notice the relaxation.
- 3 Move to shoulders: shrug up to the ears, hold, release.
- 4 Continue with feet, legs, and face muscles.

Adaptations. 3-5: use a 'squish and relax' story. 6-8: add breath to each release.

Wise Mind Connection. Progressive relaxation directly releases Emotion Mind tension while the systematic approach appeals to Robot Mind — arriving at Wise Mind calm.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Trauma-sensitive: focus on squeezing and releasing muscles, NOT a body scan. Eyes-open. Emphasize choice: students can skip any body part.

Cautions. Physical injuries — avoid affected areas.

Why it works. Alternating muscle tension and relaxation reduces physical tension and teaches the contrast between tense and relaxed states.

Evidence basis. Research-supported program component

When to use. Anxiety, sleep routines, anger, tension release.

Source: Adapted from CBT and relaxation training (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

MOVEMENT/YOGA · GRADES 6-8 · 5-10 MINUTES · ACTIVATING

Yoga Flow (Sun Salutation Adaptation)

Activity M07

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES 6-8	DURATION 5-10 minutes
SETTING Floor/movement space	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS Yoga mats (optional)	ENERGY LEVEL Activating

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Start in mountain pose: stand tall, breathe.
- 2 Reach up and breathe in.
- 3 Fold forward and breathe out.
- 4 Step back to plank, lower, and rise into a gentle cobra.
- 5 Return to mountain and repeat the flow 3 times.

Adaptations. 6-8: add breath coordination. Offer simplified versions for beginners.

Wise Mind Connection. Flowing through poses with breath awareness bridges emotional and logical pathways, a direct Wise Mind practice.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Movement-based; no touch; students choose their pace.

Cautions. Physical limitations — offer modifications.

Why it works. Flowing yoga sequences build body awareness, breath coordination, and focus while releasing physical tension.

Evidence basis. Research-supported program component

When to use. Middle schoolers, movement breaks, anxiety, focus.

Source: Adapted from yoga-in-schools research (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

MOVEMENT/YOGA · GRADES K-2/3-5/6-8 · 3-5 MINUTES · CALMING

Mindful Stretching

Activity M08

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 3-5 minutes
SETTING Desk or floor	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Calming

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Reach arms overhead and stretch up tall.
- 2 Reach to one side, then the other.
- 3 Roll the shoulders back and forward.
- 4 Gently twist the torso and notice the stretch.

Adaptations. K-2: stretch like reaching for the sky. 6-8: hold each stretch for 3 breaths.

Wise Mind Connection. Noticing areas of tension (Robot Mind observation) while releasing them (Emotion Mind regulation) practices the Wise Mind integration.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Seated stretching; no touch; eyes-open.

Cautions. Physical injuries — avoid affected areas.

Why it works. Gentle stretching releases muscle tension, increases body awareness, and provides a movement break.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Desk-based breaks, transitions, restlessness.

Source: Adapted from classroom mindfulness resources (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

MOVEMENT/YOGA · GRADES K-2/3-5 · 1-3 MINUTES · ACTIVATING

Mindful Marching

Activity M09

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5	DURATION 1-3 minutes
SETTING Open space	GROUP SIZE Whole classroom
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Activating

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 March in place slowly and rhythmically.
- 2 Notice the feet touching the floor: heel, then toe.
- 3 Match the marching to a slow count.
- 4 Gradually slow down and stop.

Adaptations. K-2: march like an elephant. 6-8: march to a metronome.

Wise Mind Connection. Rhythmic marching channels Emotion Mind energy while the counting engages Robot Mind, supporting a Wise Mind state.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Movement-based; eyes-open; non-invasive.

Cautions. Physical limitations — offer seated marching.

Why it works. Rhythmic movement channels physical energy and builds body awareness and attention.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. High energy, attention resets, transitions.

Source: Adapted from classroom mindfulness resources (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

MOVEMENT/YOGA · GRADES K-2/3-5 · 3-5 MINUTES · ACTIVATING

Bubble Balloons (Keep It Up)

Activity M10

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5	DURATION 3-5 minutes
SETTING Open space	GROUP SIZE Whole classroom
MATERIALS Multiple balloons	ENERGY LEVEL Activating

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Blow up several balloons.
- 2 Have students keep the balloons off the floor using gentle movements.
- 3 Focus on gentle touches and awareness of the balloon's path.
- 4 Notice the effort and attention needed.

Adaptations. K-2: work in pairs. 6-8: add a rule of slow, mindful touches only.

Wise Mind Connection. Balancing the balloon requires Wise Mind attention — too much force (Emotion Mind) or too little (Robot Mind detachment) and it falls.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Movement-based; no touch between students; eyes-open.

Cautions. Latex allergies — use latex-free balloons.

Why it works. Coordinated movement with visual tracking builds attention, impulse control, and group cooperation.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Group energy, movement breaks, cooperation.

Source: NAMI Mindfulness Activities (<https://www.nami.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/11/Mindfulness-Elementary.pdf>)

MOVEMENT/YOGA · GRADES K-2/3-5/6-8 · 10+ MINUTES · CALMING

Nature Walk & Notice

Activity M11

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 10+ minutes
SETTING Outdoors	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None (optional: journal)	ENERGY LEVEL Calming

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Walk outside in nature.
- 2 Notice three things you haven't noticed before.
- 3 Pause and observe each one closely.
- 4 Share what you found.

Adaptations. K-2: use a scavenger hunt list. 6-8: journal observations.

Wise Mind Connection. Walking in nature with sensory awareness calms the Emotion Mind and opens the spacious, accepting quality of Wise Mind.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; outdoor; fully optional participation.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Nature exposure combined with mindful attention reduces stress and builds present-moment awareness.

Evidence basis. Research-supported program component

When to use. Outdoor learning, anxiety, attention building.

Source: Adapted from nature mindfulness research (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

MOVEMENT/YOGA · GRADES 3-5/6-8 · 1-3 MINUTES · CALMING

Seated Spinal Twist

Activity M12

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 1-3 minutes
SETTING Desk-based	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Calming

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Sit tall in the chair.
- 2 Place one hand on the opposite knee and the other behind you.
- 3 Gently twist to one side and breathe.
- 4 Return to center and twist to the other side.

Adaptations. 3-5: keep the twist small. 6-8: hold for 3 breaths per side.

Wise Mind Connection. The gentle twist releases physical tension (Emotion Mind) while the held awareness of the body engages Wise Mind presence.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Seated; no touch; eyes-open.

Cautions. Back injuries — keep the twist gentle.

Why it works. Gentle twisting releases spinal tension and builds body awareness at the desk.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Desk breaks, attention resets, tension release.

Source: Adapted from classroom yoga resources (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

Sound/listening

9 activities in this category.

SOUND/LISTENING · GRADES K-2/3-5/6-8 · 1-3 MINUTES · FOCUSING

Golden Moment (Bell Listening)

Activity L01

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 1-3 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS Bell, tuning fork, or audio bell	ENERGY LEVEL Focusing

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Have students sit comfortably.
- 2 Ring the bell once.
- 3 Students listen and raise their hand when they can no longer hear the sound.
- 4 Repeat 2-3 times.

Adaptations. K-2: use a chime. 6-8: notice the silence after the sound.

Wise Mind Connection. Listening until the sound fades practices the Wise Mind skill of sustained attention, pulling focus away from Emotion Mind reactivity.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; raise hand when sound fades. No closing eyes required.

Cautions. Sound sensitivities — use a soft bell.

Why it works. Sustained auditory attention to a fading sound builds concentration and present-moment awareness.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Classroom centering, transitions, attention practice.

Source: NAMI Mindfulness Activities (<https://www.nami.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/11/Mindfulness-Elementary.pdf>)

SOUND/LISTENING · GRADES K-2/3-5/6-8 · 3-5 MINUTES · FOCUSING

Mindful Listening (Sounds Around)

Activity L02

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 3-5 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Focusing

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Sit quietly and listen for sounds in the room.
- 2 Notice sounds near and far.
- 3 When you hear a sound, just notice it without naming it.
- 4 Continue for several minutes.

Adaptations. K-2: share one sound after. 6-8: notice the quality of each sound.

Wise Mind Connection. Identifying sounds uses Robot Mind's categorizing while the listening itself opens Emotion Mind to the present — Wise Mind integration.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; listening outward.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Auditory orienting builds sustained attention and present-moment awareness.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Attention practice, calming, classroom centering.

Source: Adapted from mindfulness-in-schools practices (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

SOUND/LISTENING · GRADES K-2/3-5/6-8 · 3-5 MINUTES · CALMING

Chime & Breath

Activity L03

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 3-5 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS Chime or singing bowl	ENERGY LEVEL Calming

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Ring the chime and take a slow breath in.
- 2 As the sound fades, breathe out slowly.
- 3 Ring again and repeat.
- 4 Notice how the breath and sound work together.

Adaptations. K-2: ring once and breathe. 6-8: match breath length to the sound's duration.

Wise Mind Connection. Pairing sound with breath bridges Robot Mind counting and Emotion Mind calming, a direct Wise Mind practice.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; sound-based; non-invasive.

Cautions. Sound sensitivities — use a soft sound.

Why it works. Combining auditory focus with breath pacing regulates breathing and builds calm attention.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Calming, group centering, transitions.

Source: Adapted from classroom mindfulness resources (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

SOUND/LISTENING · GRADES K-2/3-5 · 3-5 MINUTES · FOCUSING

Sound Sorting (Loud/Soft)

Activity L04

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5	DURATION 3-5 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Small group
MATERIALS Various sound-making objects	ENERGY LEVEL Focusing

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Make sounds with different objects (tap, shake, scrape).
- 2 Have students sort them as loud or soft.
- 3 Then sort as high or low pitch.
- 4 Notice which sounds feel calming.

Adaptations. K-2: use simple sounds. 6-8: discuss why some sounds feel calming.

Wise Mind Connection. Sorting sounds engages Robot Mind while the listening grounds Emotion Mind, supporting Wise Mind awareness.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; sound-based; check volume sensitivities.

Cautions. Sound sensitivities — keep volumes gentle.

Why it works. Auditory discrimination builds attention and awareness of how sound affects mood.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Attention practice, sensory exploration, young children.

Source: Adapted from classroom mindfulness resources (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

SOUND/LISTENING · GRADES 3-5/6-8 · 1-3 MINUTES · FOCUSING

Silent Moment (Group Stillness)

Activity L05

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 1-3 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Whole classroom
MATERIALS Timer	ENERGY LEVEL Focusing

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Set a timer for 1-2 minutes.
- 2 The group sits in silence and stillness.
- 3 Notice sounds, feelings, and thoughts without acting on them.
- 4 End with a breath and a gentle stretch.

Adaptations. 3-5: start with 30 seconds. 6-8: build to 3 minutes.

Wise Mind Connection. Sustaining silence requires Wise Mind — neither the Emotion Mind's impulse to react nor the Robot Mind's urge to analyze, just present awareness.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; stillness is optional — students can observe if uncomfortable.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Group stillness practice builds sustained attention, impulse control, and collective calm.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Classroom centering, transitions, attention practice.

Source: Adapted from mindfulness-in-schools practices (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

SOUND/LISTENING · GRADES K-2/3-5 · 1-3 MINUTES · FOCUSING

Echo Clapping

Activity L06

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5	DURATION 1-3 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Whole classroom
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Focusing

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 The leader claps a simple pattern.
- 2 Students echo the pattern back.
- 3 Vary the speed and complexity.
- 4 Notice how attention sharpens to catch the pattern.

Adaptations. K-2: use 2-3 clap patterns. 6-8: add stomps and snaps.

Wise Mind Connection. Echo clapping engages Robot Mind's matching ability while the rhythm soothes Emotion Mind, arriving at Wise Mind.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; sound and movement; non-invasive.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Auditory-motor synchronization builds attention, working memory, and group attunement.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Transitions, attention resets, group focus.

Source: Adapted from classroom mindfulness resources (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

SOUND/LISTENING · GRADES 3-5/6-8 · 5-10 MINUTES · REFLECTIVE

Music & Feelings

Activity L07

EMOTION MIND

ROBOT MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 5-10 minutes
SETTING Quiet/private	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS Music player, selected tracks	ENERGY LEVEL Reflective

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Play a piece of instrumental music.
- 2 Listen and notice what feelings or images arise.
- 3 After the music ends, share or write one word for the feeling.
- 4 Try a contrasting piece and notice the change.

Adaptations. 3-5: draw while listening. 6-8: journal the emotions that arose.

Wise Mind Connection. Noticing how music changes feelings directly bridges Emotion Mind (feeling) and Robot Mind (noticing) — a Wise Mind practice.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Choose calming music; avoid triggering lyrics; eyes-open.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Music evokes and regulates emotion; mindful listening builds awareness of emotional response.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Emotion awareness, sadness, creative expression.

Source: Adapted from music therapy and mindfulness practices (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

SOUND/LISTENING · GRADES K-2/3-5 · 3-5 MINUTES · FOCUSING

Whisper Challenge

Activity L08

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5	DURATION 3-5 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Small group
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Focusing

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 One student whispers a word or phrase.
- 2 The next student listens carefully and repeats it.
- 3 Continue around the circle.
- 4 Compare the final phrase to the original.

Adaptations. K-2: use simple words. 6-8: use phrases and discuss how attention drifts.

Wise Mind Connection. The quiet listening required pulls focus from Emotion Mind reactivity into Wise Mind attention to the present moment.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; sound-based; non-invasive.

Cautions. Hearing difficulties — ensure clear whispers.

Why it works. Focused listening and repetition build auditory attention and awareness of how messages change.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Attention practice, group activities, fun breaks.

Source: Adapted from classroom mindfulness resources (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

SOUND/LISTENING · GRADES K-2/3-5 · 10+ MINUTES · CALMING

Mindful Storytime (Listen & Imagine)

Activity P01

EMOTION MIND

ROBOT MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5	DURATION 10+ minutes
SETTING Quiet/private	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS A storybook	ENERGY LEVEL Calming

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Read a calming story slowly.
- 2 Pause to ask what students notice or imagine.
- 3 Let them describe what they see in their minds.
- 4 End with a breath and a moment of stillness.

Adaptations. K-2: use picture books. 6-8: read a guided story.

Wise Mind Connection. Mindful storytime engages Emotion Mind's imagination while Robot Mind follows the narrative — the integration is Wise Mind listening.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; story-based; choose non-triggering stories.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Combining listening with imagination builds sustained attention and calming imagery.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Calm transitions, attention practice, young children.

Source: Adapted from classroom mindfulness resources (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

Visualization/imagery

8 activities in this category.

VISUALIZATION/IMAGERY · GRADES 3-5/6-8 · 5-10 MINUTES · CALMING

Safe Place Visualization

Activity V01

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 5-10 minutes
SETTING Quiet/private	GROUP SIZE Individual or small group
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Calming

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Close your eyes or look down, and imagine a place where you feel calm and okay.
- 2 Notice what you see there: colors, light, shapes.
- 3 Notice what you hear and feel.
- 4 Stay in this place for a few minutes, breathing slowly.

Adaptations. 3-5: draw the place after. 6-8: write a description.

Wise Mind Connection. Creating a safe place in the imagination soothes the Emotion Mind while the visualization itself engages Wise Mind's creative integration.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Trauma-sensitive: frame as 'a place where you feel okay,' not 'safe.' Eyes-open option. Emphasize choice and control — student can stop anytime.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Guided imagery of a calm place activates the relaxation response and builds an internal self-soothing resource.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Anxiety, sadness, before sleep, individual sessions.

Source: Adapted from CBT and trauma-informed practices (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

VISUALIZATION/IMAGERY · GRADES K-2/3-5/6-8 · 5-10 MINUTES · CALMING

Beach or Forest Journey

Activity V02

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 5-10 minutes
SETTING Quiet/private	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None (optional: nature sounds)	ENERGY LEVEL Calming

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Guide students to imagine walking on a beach or in a forest.
- 2 Describe the sights: waves, trees, sky.
- 3 Describe the sounds and sensations: breeze, warmth, birds.
- 4 End by taking a deep breath and returning to the room.

Adaptations. K-2: use simple imagery. 6-8: let students choose the setting.

Wise Mind Connection. Imagery engages Emotion Mind's experiential quality while the guided structure supports Robot Mind, arriving at Wise Mind's calm.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open option; emphasize it's imagination, not real.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Nature-based guided imagery evokes the relaxation response and provides a mental escape from anxiety.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Anxiety, calming, before sleep, group relaxation.

Source: Adapted from guided imagery research (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

VISUALIZATION/IMAGERY · GRADES K-2/3-5/6-8 · 3-5 MINUTES · CALMING

Color Breath Visualization

Activity V03

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 3-5 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Calming

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Choose a calming color (blue, green, etc.).
- 2 Imagine breathing in that color with each inhale.
- 3 Imagine it filling the body with calm.
- 4 Breathe out any tension as a different color.

Adaptations. K-2: name the color aloud. 6-8: describe the feeling of the color.

Wise Mind Connection. Pairing color with breath uses Robot Mind's categorizing to regulate Emotion Mind, a direct Wise Mind practice.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open option; use imagined color, not internal body focus.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Combining breath with calming color imagery provides a cognitive anchor and extends exhalation.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Anxiety, calming, sadness, individual or group.

Source: Adapted from classroom mindfulness resources (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

VISUALIZATION/IMAGERY · GRADES 3-5/6-8 · 3-5 MINUTES · FOCUSING

Thought Bubble (Watch Thoughts Pass)

Activity V04

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 3-5 minutes
SETTING Quiet/private	GROUP SIZE Individual or small group
MATERIALS None (optional: paper for drawing)	ENERGY LEVEL Focusing

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Imagine thoughts as bubbles floating by.
- 2 Watch each thought bubble without grabbing it or pushing it away.
- 3 Let it float past and watch the next one appear.
- 4 Notice that thoughts come and go on their own.

Adaptations. 3-5: draw thought bubbles on paper. 6-8: notice which thoughts recur.

Wise Mind Connection. Watching thoughts as bubbles that pop teaches the Wise Mind skill of observing thoughts without being consumed by Emotion Mind.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; frame as watching, not judging. Emphasize thoughts are not facts.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Defusion — observing thoughts as passing events reduces identification with thought content and lowers distress.

Evidence basis. Research-supported program component

When to use. Rumination, anxiety, anger, individual sessions.

Source: Adapted from ACT and mindfulness practices (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

VISUALIZATION/IMAGERY · GRADES K-2/3-5 · 10+ MINUTES · ACTIVATING

Worry Monster Creation

Activity V05

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5	DURATION 10+ minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS Box, craft supplies, scissors	ENERGY LEVEL Activating

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Have students create a monster with a cut-out mouth.
- 2 Students write or draw their worries on paper.
- 3 Feed the worries to the monster.
- 4 Discuss how giving worries away can feel lighter.

Adaptations. K-2: help write worries. 6-8: discuss which worries are controllable.

Wise Mind Connection. Externalizing worry to the monster engages Robot Mind's problem-solving while validating Emotion Mind — a Wise Mind approach.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Frame worries as external, not internal; emphasize the student controls the monster.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Externalizing worries reduces their intensity and gives children a sense of agency over anxious thoughts.

Evidence basis. Clinical/SEL-informed classroom adaptation

When to use. Anxiety, worry, individual or group sessions.

Source: NAMI Mindfulness Activities (<https://www.nami.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/11/Mindfulness-Elementary.pdf>)

VISUALIZATION/IMAGERY · GRADES K-2/3-5 · 3-5 MINUTES · CALMING

Growing Tree Visualization

Activity V06

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5	DURATION 3-5 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Calming

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Imagine being a small seed in the ground.
- 2 Feel roots growing down into the earth.
- 3 Stretch up like a tree growing toward the sun.
- 4 Feel strong and steady, breathing like a tree in the wind.

Adaptations. K-2: act it out with the body. 6-8: discuss what helps them grow.

Wise Mind Connection. Imagining growth uses Emotion Mind's creativity while the structure supports Robot Mind, cultivating Wise Mind presence.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open option; growth metaphor is affirming.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Growth imagery builds a sense of strength and grounding, countering feelings of helplessness.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Sadness, low self-esteem, grounding.

Source: Adapted from classroom mindfulness resources (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

VISUALIZATION/IMAGERY · GRADES 6-8 · 5-10 MINUTES · REFLECTIVE

Imagine Your Best Self

Activity V07

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES 6-8	DURATION 5-10 minutes
SETTING Quiet/private	GROUP SIZE Individual or small group
MATERIALS None (optional: journal)	ENERGY LEVEL Reflective

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Close your eyes or look down and imagine yourself at your best.
- 2 Notice what you're doing, how you're treating others.
- 3 Notice how you feel in this version of yourself.
- 4 Take a breath and bring that feeling into the present.

Adaptations. 6-8: write a short description after.

Wise Mind Connection. Imagining one's best self bridges Emotion Mind (aspiration) and Robot Mind (planning), a Wise Mind practice.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Frame as 'a version of yourself you'd like to be,' not a standard to meet. Eyes-open option.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Positive future-self imagery builds hope, self-efficacy, and values awareness.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Middle schoolers, sadness, self-esteem, values work.

Source: Adapted from positive psychology and mindfulness practices (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

VISUALIZATION/IMAGERY · GRADES K-2/3-5/6-8 · 3-5 MINUTES · CALMING

Star Visualization (Light & Warmth)

Activity V08

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 3-5 minutes
SETTING Quiet/private	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Calming

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Imagine a warm star above your head.
- 2 With each breath, feel its warm light flowing down through your body.
- 3 Feel the warmth filling each part: head, shoulders, chest, legs.
- 4 Rest in the warm light for a few breaths.

Adaptations. K-2: use a sun. 6-8: notice where tension releases.

Wise Mind Connection. The visualization of light and calm soothes the Emotion Mind while engaging Wise Mind's integrative awareness.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open option; light imagery is gentle and non-invasive.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Warmth and light imagery evokes the relaxation response and provides a soothing internal anchor.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Anxiety, sadness, before sleep, calming.

Source: Adapted from guided imagery practices (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

Emotion awareness

10 activities in this category.

EMOTION AWARENESS · GRADES K-2/3-5/6-8 · 1-3 MINUTES · REFLECTIVE

Feelings Check-In (Emotion Thermometer)

Activity E01

EMOTION MIND

ROBOT MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 1-3 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS Emotion thermometer or chart	ENERGY LEVEL Reflective

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Show an emotion thermometer (0-10 or calm-to-big feeling).
- 2 Students rate their current feeling level.
- 3 Name the emotion in one word.
- 4 Take a breath and notice where the feeling is in the body.

Adaptations. K-2: use faces. 6-8: use a 1-10 scale with emotion words.

Wise Mind Connection. Naming feelings is the core Wise Mind skill: Robot Mind identifies the emotion while Emotion Mind experiences it — their integration is Wise Mind.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; sharing is optional; students can point or write privately.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Affect labeling — naming and rating an emotion — reduces amygdala activation and builds emotional awareness.

Evidence basis. Research-supported program component

When to use. Daily check-ins, transitions, emotional moments.

Source: Adapted from SEL and mindfulness practices (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

EMOTION AWARENESS · GRADES K-2/3-5/6-8 · 3-5 MINUTES · REFLECTIVE

Three Good Things

Activity E02

EMOTION MIND

ROBOT MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 3-5 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None (optional: journal)	ENERGY LEVEL Reflective

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Ask students to name three good things from today.
- 2 For each, say one sentence about why it mattered.
- 3 Acknowledge that it's okay to feel sad and still notice good things.
- 4 End with a breath.

Adaptations. K-2: share orally. 6-8: write them down.

Wise Mind Connection. Noticing positives uses Robot Mind's analytical noticing to balance Emotion Mind's negativity bias, a Wise Mind practice.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; frame as noticing, not forcing positivity.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Gratitude practice retrains attention toward positive experiences, counteracting the negativity bias.

Evidence basis. Research-supported program component

When to use. End of day, sadness, low mood, gratitude practice.

Source: Mindful.org (<https://www.mindful.org/mindfulness-for-kids/>)

EMOTION AWARENESS · GRADES K-2/3-5 · 5-10 MINUTES · ACTIVATING

Emotion Charades

Activity E03

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5	DURATION 5-10 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Small group or whole class
MATERIALS Emotion cards	ENERGY LEVEL Activating

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 A student draws an emotion card (happy, angry, scared, etc.).
- 2 They act out the emotion without words.
- 3 The group guesses the emotion.
- 4 Discuss how emotions look on the body and face.

Adaptations. K-2: use simple emotions. 6-8: use complex emotions (frustrated, jealous).

Wise Mind Connection. Acting out emotions engages Emotion Mind's expressiveness while the game structure supports Robot Mind — a Wise Mind activity.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; playful; no forced disclosure.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Recognizing emotions in body language builds emotional literacy and empathy.

Evidence basis. Clinical/SEL-informed classroom adaptation

When to use. Emotion awareness, group activities, social skills.

Source: Adapted from SEL and mindfulness resources (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

EMOTION AWARENESS · GRADES 3-5/6-8 · 5-10 MINUTES · REFLECTIVE

Feelings & Body Map

Activity E04

EMOTION MIND

ROBOT MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 5-10 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Individual or small group
MATERIALS Body outline printout, colored pencils	ENERGY LEVEL Reflective

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Give each student a body outline.
- 2 Choose a color for a current emotion.
- 3 Color where that emotion shows up in the body.
- 4 Share or reflect on the connection.

Adaptations. 3-5: use simple emotions. 6-8: map multiple emotions in different colors.

Wise Mind Connection. Mapping feelings to body locations directly bridges Emotion Mind (feeling) and Robot Mind (mapping) — the essence of Wise Mind.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Trauma-sensitive: focus on where the emotion shows up, NOT a full body scan. Eyes-open. Emphasize choice — students can skip areas.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Somatic awareness of emotion builds the connection between feelings and body sensations.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Emotion awareness, anxiety, individual sessions.

Source: Adapted from CBT and mindfulness practices (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

EMOTION AWARENESS · GRADES K-2/3-5/6-8 · 5-10 MINUTES · REFLECTIVE

Gratitude Circle

Activity E05

EMOTION MIND

ROBOT MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 5-10 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Whole classroom
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Reflective

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Sit in a circle.
- 2 Each student shares one thing they're grateful for.
- 3 Acknowledge each contribution with a thank-you.
- 4 End with a group breath.

Adaptations. K-2: keep it simple. 6-8: add why it matters.

Wise Mind Connection. Gratitude circles use Robot Mind's analytical noticing to nurture Emotion Mind's positive feelings, cultivating Wise Mind.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; sharing is optional; pass is allowed.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Group gratitude practice builds positive emotion, connection, and attention to good.

Evidence basis. Research-supported program component

When to use. Group bonding, mood lifting, classroom community.

Source: Adapted from SEL and mindfulness practices (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

EMOTION AWARENESS · GRADES 3-5/6-8 · 3-5 MINUTES · REFLECTIVE

Emotion Weather Report

Activity E06

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 3-5 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Reflective

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Ask students to describe their inner weather: sunny, cloudy, stormy, foggy.
- 2 Notice that weather changes — no feeling lasts forever.
- 3 Take a breath and notice the current 'weather.'
- 4 Share or write privately.

Adaptations. 3-5: use weather pictures. 6-8: add what might change the weather.

Wise Mind Connection. Describing emotions as weather teaches the Wise Mind skill of observing emotional states without being consumed by them.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; metaphor-based; no forced disclosure.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Metaphor externalizes emotion and teaches impermanence, reducing identification with the feeling.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Emotion check-ins, sadness, anxiety, group sharing.

Source: Adapted from mindfulness-in-schools practices (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

EMOTION AWARENESS · GRADES K-2/3-5 · 5-10 MINUTES · REFLECTIVE

Mindful of Others (Noticing Kindness)

Activity E07

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5	DURATION 5-10 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Whole classroom
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Reflective

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 For one day, watch for acts of kindness in the classroom.
- 2 Notice when someone helps, shares, or includes another.
- 3 At the end of the day, share what you noticed.
- 4 Notice how it feels to see kindness.

Adaptations. K-2: share one kindness at circle time. 6-8: keep a kindness journal.

Wise Mind Connection. Noticing others' emotions engages Emotion Mind's empathy while Robot Mind observes — a Wise Mind interpersonal practice.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; observation-based; non-invasive.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Attention training toward positive social behavior builds empathy and positive classroom culture.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Social skills, conflict prevention, classroom community.

Source: Adapted from SEL and mindfulness practices (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

EMOTION AWARENESS · GRADES 3-5/6-8 · 5-10 MINUTES · REFLECTIVE

Strengths Spotting

Activity E08

EMOTION MIND

ROBOT MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 5-10 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Small group or whole class
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Reflective

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 In pairs, students name one strength they see in their partner.
- 2 The partner listens and says thank-you.
- 3 Switch roles.
- 4 Notice how it feels to give and receive a strength.

Adaptations. 3-5: use a strengths list. 6-8: write them for each other.

Wise Mind Connection. Spotting strengths uses Robot Mind's analytical noticing to nurture Emotion Mind, a Wise Mind interpersonal practice.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; strengths-based; non-invasive.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Strengths-based attention builds self-esteem, positive emotion, and social connection.

Evidence basis. Clinical/SEL-informed classroom adaptation

When to use. Self-esteem, group bonding, sadness.

Source: Adapted from positive psychology and SEL practices (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

EMOTION AWARENESS · GRADES K-2/3-5 · 3-5 MINUTES · REFLECTIVE

Feelings Flashcards

Activity E09

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5	DURATION 3-5 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS Feelings flashcards (faces)	ENERGY LEVEL Reflective

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Show a feelings flashcard with a facial expression.
- 2 Students name the emotion.
- 3 Describe a time they felt that way (optional).
- 4 Take a breath and notice the feeling.

Adaptations. K-2: match faces to words. 6-8: discuss what causes each feeling.

Wise Mind Connection. Using flashcards to identify feelings bridges Robot Mind (categorizing) and Emotion Mind (experiencing) — a Wise Mind skill.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; visual; no forced disclosure.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Emotion labeling and recognition builds emotional vocabulary and awareness.

Evidence basis. Clinical/SEL-informed classroom adaptation

When to use. Emotion awareness, young children, daily practice.

Source: Adapted from SEL resources (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

EMOTION AWARENESS · GRADES 6-8 · 3-5 MINUTES · REFLECTIVE

Emotion Wave (Riding the Feeling)

Activity E10

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES 6-8	DURATION 3-5 minutes
SETTING Quiet/private	GROUP SIZE Individual or small group
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Reflective

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Notice a strong emotion and where it sits in the body.
- 2 Watch it as a wave: rising, peaking, falling.
- 3 Remind yourself it will recede.
- 4 Breathe and observe without pushing it away or acting on it.

Adaptations. 6-8: draw the wave and label the emotion.

Wise Mind Connection. Riding the wave of an emotion is a core Wise Mind skill: acknowledging Emotion Mind without being controlled by the Emotion Mind.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; frame as watching, not suppressing. Emphasize choice to not act on the emotion.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Observing emotion as a passing wave reduces resistance and the secondary suffering of fighting the feeling.

Evidence basis. Research-supported program component

When to use. Middle schoolers, anger, anxiety, individual sessions.

Source: Adapted from DBT and mindfulness practices (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

Body awareness

8 activities in this category.

BODY AWARENESS · GRADES 3-5/6-8 · 5-10 MINUTES · CALMING

Body Scan (Calming)

Activity A01

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 5-10 minutes
SETTING Quiet/private	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None (optional: mat)	ENERGY LEVEL Calming

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Lie or sit comfortably.
- 2 Bring attention to the toes and notice sensations (or lack of).
- 3 Slowly move attention up through each body part.
- 4 End at the head, noticing the whole body.

Adaptations. 3-5: scan 5 body parts only. 6-8: full scan with breath.

Wise Mind Connection. The body scan teaches the Wise Mind skill of observing physical sensations — the bridge between Emotion Mind reactions and Robot Mind analysis.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. TRAUMA-SENSITIVE: Offer eyes-open. Frame as noticing, not scanning. Allow students to skip any body part. Provide a trauma-sensitive alternative (focus on hands or feet only). No forced body scans.

Cautions. Trauma history — use the trauma-sensitive adaptation.

Why it works. Systematic attention to body sensations builds interoceptive awareness and relaxation.

Evidence basis. Research-supported program component

When to use. Calming, before sleep, anxiety, individual sessions.

Source: Mindful.org (A Calming Body Scan, Dr. Mark Bertin) (<https://www.mindful.org/mindfulness-for-kids/>)

BODY AWARENESS · GRADES K-2/3-5/6-8 · 3-5 MINUTES · CALMING

Hands & Feet Focus (Trauma-Sensitive Body Awareness)

Activity A02

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 3-5 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Calming

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Notice your hands: their temperature, tension, position.
- 2 Squeeze and release the hands.
- 3 Notice your feet on the floor: their weight and contact.
- 4 Squeeze and release the feet. Take a breath.

Adaptations. K-2: wiggle fingers and toes. 6-8: notice tension levels.

Wise Mind Connection. Focusing on hands and feet uses Robot Mind's specific noticing to ground Emotion Mind, arriving at Wise Mind presence. Trauma-sensitive.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. TRAUMA-SENSITIVE ALTERNATIVE: Focus on hands and feet only — external, controllable body parts. Eyes-open. No full body scan.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Focusing on extremities (hands/feet) provides grounding without requiring attention to the torso, making it safer for trauma histories.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Trauma-sensitive grounding, anxiety, individual sessions.

Source: Adapted from trauma-informed mindfulness practices (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

BODY AWARENESS · GRADES 3-5/6-8 · 3-5 MINUTES · CALMING

Shoulder & Neck Release

Activity A03

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 3-5 minutes
SETTING Desk-based	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Calming

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Sit tall and roll the shoulders up to the ears.
- 2 Hold for a breath, then release down.
- 3 Gently tilt the head to one side, then the other.
- 4 Notice the release of tension.

Adaptations. 3-5: count 3 rolls. 6-8: add breath to each release.

Wise Mind Connection. Releasing shoulder tension directly addresses Emotion Mind's physical stress response while the noticing engages Wise Mind awareness.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; seated; no touch.

Cautions. Neck injuries — keep movements gentle.

Why it works. Releasing tension in the neck and shoulders reduces physical stress and builds body awareness.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Desk breaks, test stress, tension release.

Source: Adapted from classroom mindfulness resources (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

BODY AWARENESS · GRADES 3-5/6-8 · 1-3 MINUTES · FOCUSING

Mindful Posture Check

Activity A04

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 1-3 minutes
SETTING Desk-based	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Focusing

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Sit up tall and feel the feet on the floor.
- 2 Lengthen the spine and relax the shoulders.
- 3 Notice the head balanced over the spine.
- 4 Take 3 breaths in this posture.

Adaptations. 3-5: use a 'mountain pose' seated. 6-8: notice how posture affects mood.

Wise Mind Connection. Checking posture uses Robot Mind observation to regulate the body's emotional state, a Wise Mind practice.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; seated; non-invasive.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Postural awareness builds body attention and can influence mood and energy.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Transitions, attention resets, desk-based.

Source: Adapted from classroom mindfulness resources (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

BODY AWARENESS · GRADES 3-5/6-8 · 3-5 MINUTES · CALMING

Heartbeat Awareness

Activity A05

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 3-5 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Calming

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Place a hand over the heart.
- 2 Notice the heartbeat: its rhythm and strength.
- 3 Take slow breaths and notice if the heartbeat changes.
- 4 Rest in the steady rhythm.

Adaptations. 3-5: jump in place first, then feel the heartbeat. 6-8: notice the calming effect of the breath on the heart.

Wise Mind Connection. Noticing the heartbeat bridges Emotion Mind (feeling the body) and Robot Mind (counting the rate) — a Wise Mind integration.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; self-touch only; frame as noticing, not monitoring.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Interoceptive awareness of the heartbeat builds body awareness and self-regulation.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Anxiety, calming, body awareness.

Source: Adapted from mindfulness-in-schools practices (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

BODY AWARENESS · GRADES 3-5/6-8 · 1-3 MINUTES · FOCUSING

Mindful Standing (Mountain Pose)

Activity A06

EMOTION MIND

ROBOT MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 1-3 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Focusing

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Stand tall with feet hip-width apart.
- 2 Feel the four corners of the feet on the ground.
- 3 Lengthen the spine and relax the shoulders.
- 4 Breathe and feel strong and steady like a mountain.

Adaptations. 3-5: hold for 30 seconds. 6-8: add a slow breath count.

Wise Mind Connection. Mountain pose requires the stillness and integration of Wise Mind — neither Emotion Mind restlessness nor Robot Mind detachment.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; standing; non-invasive.

Cautions. Balance issues — offer seated version.

Why it works. Grounded standing posture builds body awareness, stability, and present-moment attention.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Attention resets, transitions, grounding.

Source: Adapted from yoga-in-schools practices (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

BODY AWARENESS · GRADES K-2/3-5/6-8 · 3-5 MINUTES · CALMING

Face Relaxation (Melt the Tension)

Activity A07

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 3-5 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Calming

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Notice tension in the forehead and jaw.
- 2 Squeeze the face up tight, then release.
- 3 Open the mouth wide, then relax.
- 4 Smile gently and notice the shift.

Adaptations. K-2: make silly faces. 6-8: notice the difference between tense and relaxed.

Wise Mind Connection. Relaxing facial muscles releases Emotion Mind tension while the noticing engages Wise Mind's body awareness.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; no touch; facial focus only.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Releasing facial tension reduces physical stress and builds awareness of how emotion shows in the face.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Anxiety, anger, tension release, desk-based.

Source: Adapted from relaxation training (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

BODY AWARENESS · GRADES K-2/3-5/6-8 · 1-3 MINUTES · CALMING

Squeeze & Let Go (Fists)

Activity A08

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 1-3 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Calming

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Squeeze both fists as tight as possible.
- 2 Hold for 5 seconds.
- 3 Release and notice the relaxation.
- 4 Repeat 3 times, noticing the contrast.

Adaptations. K-2: pretend to squeeze a lemon. 6-8: add breath to the release.

Wise Mind Connection. Squeezing and releasing muscles teaches the Wise Mind skill of noticing contrast — between Emotion Mind tension and Wise Mind calm.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; self-directed; non-invasive.

Cautions. Hand injuries — keep gentle.

Why it works. Contrastive muscle relaxation teaches the difference between tension and release, building body awareness.

Evidence basis. Research-supported program component

When to use. Anger, anxiety, tension release, quick resets.

Source: Adapted from progressive muscle relaxation (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

Compassion/kindness

9 activities in this category.

COMPASSION/KINDNESS · GRADES 3-5/6-8 · 3-5 MINUTES · REFLECTIVE

Loving-Kindness for Kids

Activity C01

EMOTION MIND

ROBOT MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 3-5 minutes
SETTING Quiet/private	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Reflective

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Sit comfortably and bring to mind someone you love.
- 2 Silently wish them: 'May you be happy. May you be safe.'
- 3 Then wish the same for yourself.
- 4 Then for a neutral person, and finally for someone difficult.

Adaptations. 3-5: use simple phrases. 6-8: add 'May you be at peace.'

Wise Mind Connection. Loving-kindness is a core Wise Mind practice: it requires both Emotion Mind's warmth and Robot Mind's intention — their integration is Wise Mind.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; frame as wishing well, not forcing feelings. Allow choice of who to include.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Compassion meditation activates the affiliative/soothing system, reducing self-criticism and building social connection.

Evidence basis. Research-supported program component

When to use. Sadness, conflict, self-compassion, group practice.

Source: Mindful.org (Kindness Meditation for Families) (<https://www.mindful.org/mindfulness-for-kids/>)

COMPASSION/KINDNESS · GRADES K-2/3-5/6-8 · 3-5 MINUTES · REFLECTIVE

Kind Words to Self

Activity C02

EMOTION MIND

ROBOT MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 3-5 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Reflective

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Place a hand on the heart.
- 2 Say silently or aloud: 'May I be happy. May I be safe. May I be kind to myself.'
- 3 Repeat 3 times.
- 4 Notice any shift, even small.

Adaptations. K-2: use 'I am okay.' 6-8: let students choose their own kind phrase.

Wise Mind Connection. Self-compassion directly addresses the gap between Robot Mind's harsh self-criticism and Emotion Mind's pain — Wise Mind holds both.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; frame as practice, not feeling. Emphasize choice of words.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Self-compassion practice activates the soothing system and reduces shame-based self-criticism.

Evidence basis. Research-supported program component

When to use. Sadness, self-criticism, anxiety, end of day.

Source: Adapted from Mindful.org kindness practices (<https://www.mindful.org/mindfulness-for-kids/>)

COMPASSION/KINDNESS · GRADES K-2/3-5/6-8 · 5-10 MINUTES · REFLECTIVE

Compliment Circle

Activity C03

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 5-10 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Whole classroom
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Reflective

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Sit in a circle.
- 2 Each student gives a genuine compliment to the person next to them.
- 3 The receiver says 'Thank you.'
- 4 Continue around the circle.

Adaptations. K-2: use sentence starters ('You are...'). 6-8: give specific, genuine compliments.

Wise Mind Connection. Giving compliments engages Emotion Mind's warmth while the structure supports Robot Mind — a Wise Mind social practice.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; sharing is optional; pass is allowed.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Giving and receiving compliments builds positive emotion, social connection, and self-esteem.

Evidence basis. Clinical/SEL-informed classroom adaptation

When to use. Group bonding, conflict repair, mood lifting.

Source: Adapted from SEL and mindfulness practices (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

COMPASSION/KINDNESS · GRADES 3-5/6-8 · 10+ MINUTES · REFLECTIVE

Gratitude Letter (Thank You Note)

Activity C04

EMOTION MIND

ROBOT MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 10+ minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Individual
MATERIALS Paper, pencil, envelope	ENERGY LEVEL Reflective

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Think of someone who has helped or cared for you.
- 2 Write a short thank-you note to them.
- 3 Be specific about what they did and how it helped.
- 4 Deliver it if possible.

Adaptations. 3-5: draw and write one sentence. 6-8: write a full letter.

Wise Mind Connection. Writing gratitude uses Robot Mind's analytical skills to nurture Emotion Mind's appreciation, a Wise Mind practice.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; writing-based; non-invasive.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Gratitude expression builds positive emotion, connection, and meaning.

Evidence basis. Research-supported program component

When to use. Sadness, gratitude, connection, individual work.

Source: Adapted from positive psychology practices (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

COMPASSION/KINDNESS · GRADES K-2/3-5 · 3-5 MINUTES · REFLECTIVE

Heartfulness Practice (Wishing Well)

Activity C05

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5	DURATION 3-5 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Reflective

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Place a hand on the heart.
- 2 Think of someone who is having a hard time.
- 3 Silently wish them well: 'I hope you feel better.'
- 4 Notice how it feels to care for someone.

Adaptations. K-2: wish for a pet or friend. 6-8: wish for someone who is struggling.

Wise Mind Connection. Heartfulness cultivates the Wise Mind quality of holding both emotional warmth and present-moment awareness simultaneously.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; wishing, not forcing; non-invasive.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Compassion practice builds empathy and positive social emotion.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Empathy building, conflict, group community.

Source: Adapted from Mindful Schools heartfulness practices (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

COMPASSION/KINDNESS · GRADES 6-8 · 5-10 MINUTES · REFLECTIVE

Forgiveness Practice (Let It Go)

Activity C06

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES 6-8	DURATION 5-10 minutes
SETTING Quiet/private	GROUP SIZE Individual or small group
MATERIALS None (optional: journal)	ENERGY LEVEL Reflective

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Think of a small hurt or frustration you're carrying.
- 2 Acknowledge the feeling without judging it.
- 3 Silently say: 'I don't have to carry this. I can let it go.'
- 4 Take a breath and notice any lightness.

Adaptations. 6-8: write the hurt on paper and then tear it up.

Wise Mind Connection. Forgiveness requires Wise Mind — acknowledging Emotion Mind's hurt while choosing Robot Mind's reasoning to release it.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; frame as releasing the burden, not excusing harm. Emphasize choice and safety.

Cautions. Active abuse or danger — prioritize safety over forgiveness.

Why it works. Forgiveness practice reduces the emotional burden of holding anger and builds emotional flexibility.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Middle schoolers, anger, conflict, individual sessions.

Source: Adapted from Mindful.org forgiveness practice (<https://www.mindful.org/mindfulness-for-kids/>)

COMPASSION/KINDNESS · GRADES 3-5/6-8 · 5-10 MINUTES · REFLECTIVE

Noticing Good in Others

Activity C07

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 5-10 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Reflective

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Pick one person in the room.
- 2 Silently notice one good thing about them.
- 3 Optionally share it with them.
- 4 Notice how it feels to look for the good.

Adaptations. 3-5: share orally. 6-8: write it on a sticky note for them.

Wise Mind Connection. Noticing good in others uses Robot Mind observation to nurture Emotion Mind's connection, a Wise Mind interpersonal practice.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; observation-based; non-invasive.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Training attention toward positive qualities in others builds empathy and positive social emotion.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Social skills, conflict, classroom community.

Source: Adapted from SEL and mindfulness practices (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

COMPASSION/KINDNESS · GRADES K-2/3-5/6-8 · 3-5 MINUTES · REFLECTIVE

Self-Appreciation (One Good Thing About Me)

Activity C08

EMOTION MIND

ROBOT MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 3-5 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None (optional: journal)	ENERGY LEVEL Reflective

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Think of one good thing about yourself.
- 2 It can be small: kind, helpful, creative, funny.
- 3 Say it silently or write it down.
- 4 Take a breath and let it sink in.

Adaptations. K-2: share orally. 6-8: write three good things about yourself.

Wise Mind Connection. Self-appreciation bridges Robot Mind's self-evaluation and Emotion Mind's self-worth — the integration is Wise Mind.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; frame as noticing, not bragging; sharing is optional.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Self-directed positive attention builds self-esteem and counters the negativity bias.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Self-esteem, sadness, anxiety, individual work.

Source: Adapted from positive psychology and mindfulness practices (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

COMPASSION/KINDNESS · GRADES 3-5/6-8 · 10+ MINUTES · CALMING

Gratitude Walk

Activity P05

EMOTION MIND

ROBOT MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 10+ minutes
SETTING Outdoors	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None (optional: journal)	ENERGY LEVEL Calming

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Walk outside and notice things you're grateful for.
- 2 Name one thing from each sense.
- 3 Pause and appreciate each one.
- 4 Share or write them after.

Adaptations. 3-5: use a scavenger list. 6-8: journal the gratitude.

Wise Mind Connection. Gratitude walks use Robot Mind's noticing to nurture Emotion Mind's appreciation, a Wise Mind movement practice.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; movement; non-invasive.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Combining nature exposure with gratitude practice builds positive emotion and present-moment awareness.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Outdoor activities, sadness, gratitude practice.

Source: Adapted from nature and gratitude mindfulness (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

Attention/focus

9 activities in this category.

ATTENTION/FOCUS · GRADES 3-5/6-8 · 3-5 MINUTES · FOCUSING

Mindful Counting

Activity F01

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 3-5 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Focusing

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Close eyes or look down.
- 2 Count backward from 100 (or a smaller number).
- 3 If the mind wanders, start over.
- 4 Notice when attention drifts and gently return.

Adaptations. 3-5: count down from 20. 6-8: count by 2s or 7s for added challenge.

Wise Mind Connection. Sustained counting is a Wise Mind practice: it requires neither the Emotion Mind's reactivity nor Robot Mind's detachment, just present attention.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; counting is grounding; non-invasive.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Sustained counting builds working memory and metacognitive awareness of attention.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Attention practice, anxiety, focus building.

Source: NAMI Mindfulness Activities (<https://www.nami.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/11/Mindfulness-Elementary.pdf>)

ATTENTION/FOCUS · GRADES K-2/3-5/6-8 · 3-5 MINUTES · FOCUSING

Finger Labyrinths

Activity F02

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 3-5 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS Printed finger labyrinth, pencil	ENERGY LEVEL Focusing

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Give each student a printed finger labyrinth.
- 2 Trace the path to the center with a finger.
- 3 Pause at the center and take a breath.
- 4 Trace the path back out.

Adaptations. K-2: use simple labyrinths. 6-8: try with the non-dominant hand.

Wise Mind Connection. Walking the labyrinth engages Robot Mind's spatial processing while calming Emotion Mind, arriving at Wise Mind's focused calm.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; tactile; non-invasive.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Tactile-visual tracing sustains attention and provides a calming, meditative focus.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Attention practice, calming, individual work.

Source: NAMI Mindfulness Activities (<https://www.nami.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/11/Mindfulness-Elementary.pdf>)

ATTENTION/FOCUS · GRADES K-2/3-5 · 5-10 MINUTES · FOCUSING

iSPY (Mindful Observation)

Activity F03

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5	DURATION 5-10 minutes
SETTING Outdoors or classroom	GROUP SIZE Small group
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Focusing

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Walk outside or around the room in small groups.
- 2 One student says 'I spy...' and describes an object.
- 3 Others try to guess what it is.
- 4 Switch after each round.

Adaptations. K-2: use colors. 6-8: use descriptive clues.

Wise Mind Connection. The visual search uses Robot Mind's observational power to regulate Emotion Mind, a Wise Mind attention practice.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; movement-based; non-invasive.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Visual scanning and description builds sustained attention and observational awareness.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Attention practice, outdoor activities, group fun.

Source: NAMI Mindfulness Activities (<https://www.nami.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/11/Mindfulness-Elementary.pdf>)

ATTENTION/FOCUS · GRADES K-2/3-5/6-8 · 10+ MINUTES · CALMING

Mindful Coloring

Activity F04

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 10+ minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS Coloring pages, colored pencils or crayons	ENERGY LEVEL Calming

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Give each student a coloring page.
- 2 Color slowly, paying attention to the colors and strokes.
- 3 Notice the feeling of the pencil on the paper.
- 4 If the mind wanders, return to the coloring.

Adaptations. K-2: use simple pages. 6-8: use mandalas or complex patterns.

Wise Mind Connection. Coloring with attention requires Wise Mind: noticing when Emotion Mind pulls attention away and gently returning — a core DBT practice.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; tactile; non-invasive; calming and safe.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Sustained visual-motor attention to coloring induces a meditative, flow-like state that reduces anxiety.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Calming, anxiety, individual work, transitions.

Source: Adapted from classroom mindfulness resources (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

ATTENTION/FOCUS · GRADES K-2/3-5 · 5-10 MINUTES · ACTIVATING

Simon Says (Body Attention)

Activity F05

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5	DURATION 5-10 minutes
SETTING Open space	GROUP SIZE Whole classroom
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Activating

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 One person is the leader and gives movements with 'Simon says.'
- 2 Students do the movement only when 'Simon says' is used.
- 3 If not, they stay still.
- 4 Try multiple leaders.

Adaptations. K-2: use simple movements. 6-8: add complex sequences.

Wise Mind Connection. Simon Says engages Robot Mind's listening while requiring Emotion Mind's impulse control — the balance is Wise Mind.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; movement; non-invasive.

Cautions. Physical limitations — offer seated alternatives.

Why it works. Listening-and-responding with impulse control builds sustained attention and body awareness.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Movement breaks, attention practice, young children.

Source: NAMI Mindfulness Activities (<https://www.nami.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/11/Mindfulness-Elementary.pdf>)

ATTENTION/FOCUS · GRADES K-2/3-5 · 3-5 MINUTES · FOCUSING

Find the Difference (Visual Attention)

Activity F06

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5	DURATION 3-5 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS Find-the-difference pictures	ENERGY LEVEL Focusing

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Give students two nearly identical pictures.
- 2 Find the differences between them.
- 3 Work slowly and carefully.
- 4 Notice how attention sharpens with focus.

Adaptations. K-2: use 3-5 differences. 6-8: use complex scenes.

Wise Mind Connection. Finding differences uses Robot Mind observation while the focus calms Emotion Mind, a Wise Mind attention practice.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; visual; non-invasive.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Sustained visual comparison builds attention to detail and concentration.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Attention practice, individual work, calm transitions.

Source: Adapted from classroom attention resources (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

ATTENTION/FOCUS · GRADES 3-5/6-8 · 5-10 MINUTES · CALMING

Mindful Listening to Music

Activity F07

EMOTION MIND

ROBOT MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 5-10 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS Music player, instrumental track	ENERGY LEVEL Calming

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Play a piece of instrumental music.
- 2 Listen for one instrument throughout the piece.
- 3 When you hear it, notice its sound and rhythm.
- 4 Share what you noticed after.

Adaptations. 3-5: listen for the beat. 6-8: listen for a specific instrument.

Wise Mind Connection. Listening deeply to music engages Emotion Mind's feeling and Robot Mind's noticing — their integration is Wise Mind listening.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; choose non-triggering instrumental music.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Selective auditory attention builds sustained concentration and present-moment awareness.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Attention practice, calming, group activities.

Source: Adapted from music and mindfulness practices (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

ATTENTION/FOCUS · GRADES 3-5/6-8 · 1-3 MINUTES · FOCUSING

One-Minute Focus Challenge

Activity F08

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 1-3 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS Timer, small object (stone, coin)	ENERGY LEVEL Focusing

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Set a timer for one minute.
- 2 Focus all attention on a single small object.
- 3 Notice every detail: color, texture, weight.
- 4 If the mind wanders, return to the object.

Adaptations. 3-5: start with 30 seconds. 6-8: try with eyes closed (optional).

Wise Mind Connection. One-minute focus is a condensed Wise Mind practice: noticing when Emotion Mind pulls away and returning to the anchor.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; visual focus; non-invasive.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Sustained visual attention to a single object builds concentration and metacognitive awareness.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Attention practice, quick resets, focus building.

Source: Adapted from mindfulness-in-schools practices (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

ATTENTION/FOCUS · GRADES 3-5/6-8 · 1-3 MINUTES · FOCUSING

Mindful Transitions (One Thing at a Time)

Activity P06

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 1-3 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Focusing

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 When transitioning to a new task, pause.
- 2 Take one breath and notice the change.
- 3 Set an intention for the next task.
- 4 Begin with full attention on one thing.

Adaptations. 3-5: name the new task. 6-8: set a specific intention.

Wise Mind Connection. Mindful transitions require Wise Mind: noticing the shift between activities without Emotion Mind resistance or Robot Mind rushing.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; non-invasive; builds on routine.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Pausing at transitions builds metacognitive awareness and single-tasking attention.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Transitions, focus building, daily practice.

Source: Adapted from mindfulness-in-schools practices (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

Social/group mindfulness

7 activities in this category.

SOCIAL/GROUP MINDFULNESS · GRADES K-2/3-5/6-8 · 1-3 MINUTES · REFLECTIVE

Mindful Greetings

Activity G01

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 1-3 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Whole classroom
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Reflective

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 At the start of class, greet each student by name.
- 2 Make eye contact and offer a genuine welcome.
- 3 Students greet each other in pairs.
- 4 Notice how it feels to be seen and welcomed.

Adaptations. K-2: use a greeting choice (wave, fist bump, verbal). 6-8: ask about their day.

Wise Mind Connection. Mindful greetings use Robot Mind's social scripts while engaging Emotion Mind's connection — a Wise Mind relational practice.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; no forced touch; verbal greetings only.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Being seen and greeted builds connection, belonging, and present-moment social awareness.

Evidence basis. Clinical/SEL-informed classroom adaptation

When to use. Morning meeting, classroom community, transitions.

Source: Adapted from SEL and mindfulness practices (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

SOCIAL/GROUP MINDFULNESS · GRADES K-2/3-5/6-8 · 3-5 MINUTES · CALMING

Pass the Squeeze (Group Pulse)

Activity G02

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 3-5 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Whole classroom
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Calming

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Stand or sit in a circle, holding hands.
- 2 The leader gently squeezes the next hand.
- 3 The squeeze passes around the circle.
- 4 Notice when it returns and how the group synced.

Adaptations. K-2: keep it simple. 6-8: add a breath to each squeeze. Offer no-touch alternative: pass a gentle nod.

Wise Mind Connection. Passing the squeeze requires Wise Mind attention — noticing the sensation and passing it on, neither reacting (Emotion Mind) nor ignoring (Robot Mind).

Trauma-Sensitive Note. TRIGGER WARNING: involves hand-holding. Offer an alternative (pass a gentle nod or pass an object) for students who prefer no touch.

Cautions. Touch aversion or trauma — offer no-touch alternative.

Why it works. Group synchronization through gentle touch builds social connection and collective calm.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Group bonding, classroom community, calming.

Source: Adapted from group mindfulness practices (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

SOCIAL/GROUP MINDFULNESS · GRADES 3-5/6-8 · 1-3 MINUTES · REFLECTIVE

Mindful Eye Contact (Partner Gaze)

Activity G03

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 1-3 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Pairs
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Reflective

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 In pairs, face each other.
- 2 Look into each other's eyes for 30 seconds (or look at hands).
- 3 Notice what you see and feel without speaking.
- 4 Share one observation after.

Adaptations. 3-5: 15 seconds. 6-8: 1 minute with a breath.

Wise Mind Connection. Eye contact requires Wise Mind: holding Emotion Mind's vulnerability with Robot Mind's intention — their integration is connection.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; frame as noticing, not staring. Offer looking at hands instead for discomfort. Allow opt-out.

Cautions. Social anxiety or trauma — offer alternative (look at hands).

Why it works. Sustained eye contact builds social connection, presence, and awareness of the other.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Social skills, empathy, conflict repair.

Source: Adapted from group mindfulness practices (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

SOCIAL/GROUP MINDFULNESS · GRADES K-2/3-5/6-8 · 3-5 MINUTES · CALMING

Group Breath (Synchronized Breathing)

Activity G04

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 3-5 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Whole classroom
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Calming

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Sit in a circle.
- 2 The leader breathes in, and the group follows.
- 3 Breathe out together slowly.
- 4 Continue for several rounds, syncing the breath.

Adaptations. K-2: use a visual cue (hands up/down). 6-8: add a count.

Wise Mind Connection. Group breathing synchronizes Emotion Mind (shared calm) and Robot Mind (shared rhythm) — a collective Wise Mind experience.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; non-invasive; synchronized but not touching.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Group breath synchronization builds collective calm, social attunement, and present-moment awareness.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Group centering, transitions, anxiety, classroom community.

Source: Adapted from mindfulness-in-schools practices (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

SOCIAL/GROUP MINDFULNESS · GRADES 3-5/6-8 · 5-10 MINUTES · REFLECTIVE

Mindful Sharing Circle

Activity G05

EMOTION MIND

ROBOT MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 5-10 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Whole classroom
MATERIALS A talking object	ENERGY LEVEL Reflective

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Sit in a circle with a talking object.
- 2 The holder shares one feeling or experience.
- 3 Others listen without commenting.
- 4 Pass the object to the next person.

Adaptations. 3-5: share one word. 6-8: share a short reflection.

Wise Mind Connection. Sharing in a circle bridges Emotion Mind (expressing) and Robot Mind (listening) — the group holds both, which is Wise Mind.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; sharing is optional; pass is always allowed.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Mindful speaking and listening builds empathy, connection, and emotional awareness.

Evidence basis. Clinical/SEL-informed classroom adaptation

When to use. Group bonding, emotion awareness, classroom community.

Source: Adapted from SEL and mindfulness practices (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

SOCIAL/GROUP MINDFULNESS · GRADES K-2/3-5 · 3-5 MINUTES · FOCUSING

Noticing Together (Shared Observation)

Activity G06

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5	DURATION 3-5 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Pairs or small group
MATERIALS An object (leaf, stone, photo)	ENERGY LEVEL Focusing

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 In pairs, choose an object.
- 2 Together, notice and describe its details.
- 3 Take turns pointing out things you see.
- 4 Share what you noticed with the group.

Adaptations. K-2: use familiar objects. 6-8: sketch together.

Wise Mind Connection. Noticing together uses Robot Mind observation while creating Emotion Mind connection, a Wise Mind shared practice.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; observation-based; non-invasive.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Shared attention to an object builds social connection and present-moment awareness.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Attention practice, pair work, group bonding.

Source: Adapted from classroom mindfulness resources (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

SOCIAL/GROUP MINDFULNESS · GRADES 3-5/6-8 · 5-10 MINUTES · REFLECTIVE

Appreciation Circle (Gratitude for Others)

Activity G07

EMOTION MIND

ROBOT MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 5-10 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Whole classroom
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Reflective

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Sit in a circle.
- 2 Each student names one thing they appreciate about the class or a classmate.
- 3 The group says 'Thank you' together.
- 4 End with a group breath.

Adaptations. 3-5: use sentence starters. 6-8: be specific and genuine.

Wise Mind Connection. Appreciation circles use Robot Mind's noticing to nurture Emotion Mind's warmth, a Wise Mind relational practice.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; sharing is optional; pass is allowed.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Group appreciation builds positive emotion, social connection, and classroom community.

Evidence basis. Clinical/SEL-informed classroom adaptation

When to use. Group bonding, conflict repair, mood lifting.

Source: Adapted from SEL and mindfulness practices (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

Transition/reset

6 activities in this category.

TRANSITION/RESET · GRADES K-2/3-5/6-8 · UNDER 1 MINUTE · CALMING

30-Second Reset (Quick Breath)

Activity T01

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5, 6-8	DURATION Under 1 minute
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Calming

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Stop and take one slow breath in.
- 2 Take one slow breath out.
- 3 Notice the feet on the floor.
- 4 Return to the task.

Adaptations. K-2: 'take a balloon breath.' 6-8: add a shoulder drop.

Wise Mind Connection. The 30-second reset is a rapid Wise Mind tool: noticing when Emotion Mind or Robot Mind has taken over and returning to balanced awareness.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; self-directed; non-invasive.

Cautions. None

Why it works. A single mindful breath interrupts automatic reactivity and resets attention.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Quick transitions, between activities, resets.

Source: Adapted from classroom mindfulness resources (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

TRANSITION/RESET · GRADES 3-5/6-8 · 1-3 MINUTES · CALMING

Desk Reset (Sit & Breathe)

Activity T02

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 1-3 minutes
SETTING Desk-based	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Calming

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Sit up tall at the desk.
- 2 Place feet flat on the floor.
- 3 Take 5 slow breaths, counting each one.
- 4 Notice the body settling.

Adaptations. 3-5: use 3 breaths. 6-8: add a calming word per breath.

Wise Mind Connection. Desk reset uses Robot Mind's structure to regulate Emotion Mind, quickly returning to Wise Mind presence.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; seated; non-invasive.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Brief seated breathing regulates the nervous system and prepares for focused work.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Transitions, before tests, desk-based resets.

Source: Adapted from classroom mindfulness resources (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

TRANSITION/RESET · GRADES K-2/3-5/6-8 · 1-3 MINUTES · CALMING

Mindful Line-Up (Waiting Practice)

Activity T03

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 1-3 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Whole classroom
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Calming

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Stand in line quietly.
- 2 Notice the feet on the floor and the body standing tall.
- 3 Take 3 slow breaths.
- 4 Notice sounds around without reacting.

Adaptations. K-2: 'stand like a tree.' 6-8: add a focus point.

Wise Mind Connection. Mindful lining up requires Wise Mind: neither Emotion Mind's pushing nor Robot Mind's rigid compliance, just present-moment awareness.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; standing; non-invasive.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Standing mindfulness in transitions builds impulse control and present-moment awareness.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Line-ups, hallway transitions, waiting times.

Source: Adapted from classroom mindfulness resources (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

TRANSITION/RESET · GRADES K-2/3-5/6-8 · 1-3 MINUTES · ACTIVATING

Brain Break (Movement Reset)

Activity T04

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 1-3 minutes
SETTING Open space or desk	GROUP SIZE Whole classroom
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Activating

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Stand up and shake out the arms and legs.
- 2 Do 5 jumping jacks or march in place.
- 3 Take a deep breath and settle.
- 4 Return to the seat refreshed.

Adaptations. K-2: use animal movements. 6-8: add a breath between movements.

Wise Mind Connection. Brain breaks release Emotion Mind energy while the structure supports Robot Mind, returning to Wise Mind readiness.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; movement; non-invasive.

Cautions. Physical limitations — offer seated alternatives.

Why it works. Brief physical movement releases restlessness and resets attention for focused work.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Restlessness, transitions, attention resets.

Source: Adapted from classroom brain break research (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

TRANSITION/RESET · GRADES K-2/3-5 · 1-3 MINUTES · CALMING

Quiet Hands (Calm Down Quickly)

Activity T05

EMOTION MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES K-2, 3-5	DURATION 1-3 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None	ENERGY LEVEL Calming

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Place hands palms-down on the desk.
- 2 Press gently and notice the pressure.
- 3 Take 3 slow breaths.
- 4 Feel the hands relax and the body settle.

Adaptations. K-2: 'press like a turtle.' 6-8: notice tension leaving the hands.

Wise Mind Connection. Quiet hands is a Wise Mind practice: noticing the impulse to move (Emotion Mind) and choosing stillness (Wise Mind) — not forcing (Robot Mind).

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; self-directed; non-invasive.

Cautions. None

Why it works. Tactile grounding and gentle pressure provide a quick, self-directed calming tool.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. Anger, restlessness, quick resets, transitions.

Source: Adapted from classroom mindfulness resources (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)

TRANSITION/RESET · GRADES 3-5/6-8 · 3-5 MINUTES · REFLECTIVE

End-of-Day Reflection

Activity T06

EMOTION MIND

ROBOT MIND

WISE MIND

GRADES 3-5, 6-8	DURATION 3-5 minutes
SETTING Any	GROUP SIZE Any
MATERIALS None (optional: journal)	ENERGY LEVEL Reflective

HOW TO DO IT

- 1 Take a breath and notice the body.
- 2 Name one thing that went well today.
- 3 Name one thing that was hard.
- 4 Set an intention for tomorrow.

Adaptations. 3-5: share orally. 6-8: write in a journal.

Wise Mind Connection. End-of-day reflection bridges Emotion Mind (experiencing the day) and Robot Mind (summarizing) — the integration is Wise Mind.

Trauma-Sensitive Note. Eyes-open; reflection is private; sharing is optional.

Cautions. None

Why it works. End-of-day reflection builds metacognitive awareness, gratitude, and emotional processing.

Evidence basis. Evidence-informed mindfulness practice

When to use. End of day, transitions home, reflection practice.

Source: Adapted from classroom mindfulness resources (<https://www.mindfulschools.org>)